

Audio description quality

Systematic scoping review

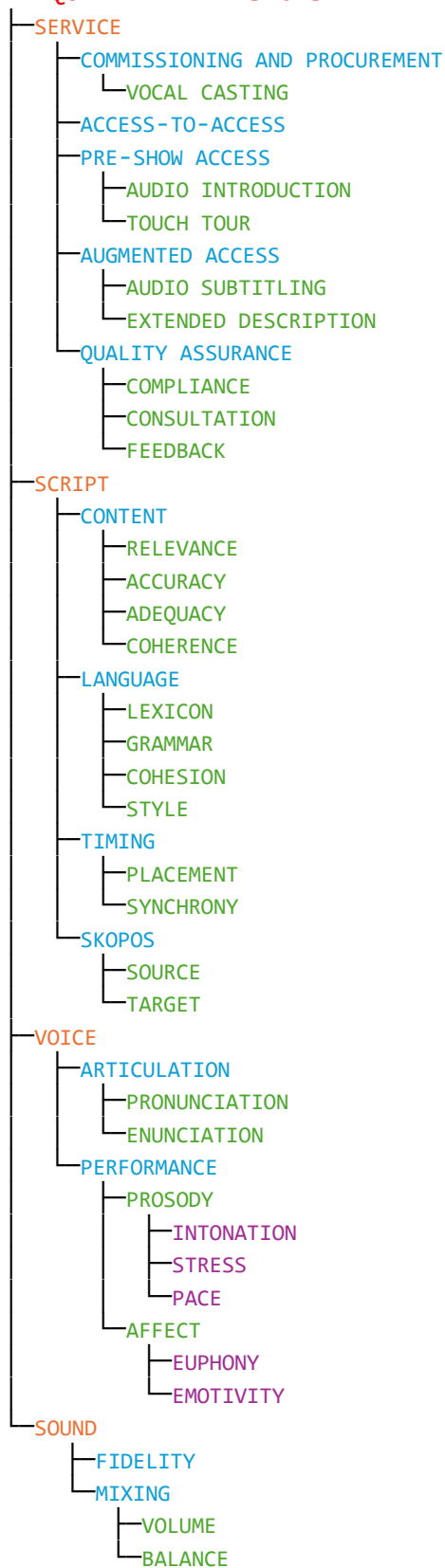
Codebook guide

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Codebook

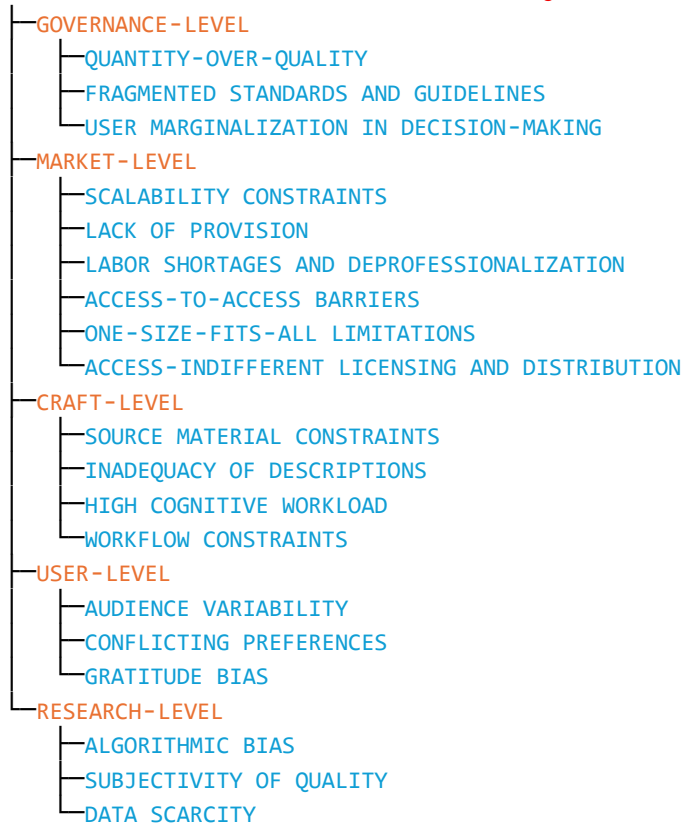
AD QUALITY DIMENSIONS



METHODS OF AD QUALITY ASSESSMENT

- EVALUATOR
- RESEARCH PARADIGM
- DATA COLLECTION METHOD
- MEASUREMENT TOOL

CHALLENGES AND LIMITATIONS IN AD QUALITY



Codebook guide

AD quality dimensions

Definition

A taxonomy of the evaluative aspects and attributes that constitute AD quality across the production lifecycle. This framework organizes AD quality into four hierarchical domains that map onto real-world agential chains: **SERVICE** (provision infrastructure and access conditions), **SCRIPT** (descriptive content and textual composition), **VOICE** (vocal performance), and **SOUND** (audio engineering and technical execution). The agential structure of the domains prevents collapsing institutional quality (who provides access, under what conditions) with core content quality (how well the script is written), its vocal performance (how well it is performed), or its technical execution (how well the performance is integrated into the soundtrack).

Scope

The **QUALITY DIMENSIONS** framework describes **WHAT** aspects of AD are evaluated for quality, categorically distinct from **HOW** quality is assessed (**METHODS OF AD QUALITY ASSESSMENT**) or **WHAT** impedes quality (**CHALLENGES AND LIMITATIONS IN AD QUALITY**). Items belong in **QUALITY DIMENSIONS** when they describe observable, assessable features of AD products or processes, namely the actual characteristics that can be judged from the perspective of quality.

Levels of the framework

The framework is hierarchical, and the article names its levels. A parent node is a dimension: one of the four sites at which AD quality is produced. A child node is a facet: a situated site within a dimension at which quality becomes actionable. A grandchild node is a realization: the specific provision, criterion, or technique by which a facet is judged, with great-grandchildren specifying a realization further. The bracketed tags used throughout this guide—**[PARENT]**, **[CHILD]**, **[GRANDCHILD]**, **[GREAT-GRANDCHILD]**—are the coding labels for those same levels. A **TOUCH TOUR** is therefore not a dimension but a realization two grains down: a provision by which **PRE-SHOW ACCESS** is judged, not a category at the same analytical level as **SERVICE**.

What makes a dimension

Not every recurring topic is a dimension. An aspect of AD is treated as dimensional when three conditions hold together: quality can be won or lost there; an identifiable agent can act on it; and failure at that site cannot be remedied elsewhere. The third condition is the decisive one. The test is irreducibility. The four dimensions are studied very unevenly and yet form the smallest set of sites whose breakdowns no other can absorb. A describer cannot solve a platform's discoverability problem; a voice talent cannot rescue an AD track mixed

too low; a sound engineer cannot compensate for a script that omits relevant information. Apply this test whenever a candidate item seems to warrant a node of its own: if the concern can be repaired at another site, it is a facet or a realization of that site, not a dimension.

Read together, the four dimensions form an agential ecology. Quality is not lodged in a single artefact but produced across distributed sites of action—platforms, venues, access providers, describers, consultants, voice talents, sound engineers, regulators, researchers, and users—which act at different stages and from different positions. The framework is therefore diagnostic rather than summative: it relocates the question from a global judgment (is this AD good?) to a locatable one—good in which respect, at which site, and under whose agency?

AD QUALITY DIMENSIONS **cheat sheet**

Parent	Question	Focus
SERVICE	How is AD provided to users?	Provision & access conditions
SCRIPT	How is AD written?	Descriptive content & wording
VOICE	How is the script performed?	Vocal performance of script
SOUND	How is the performance integrated into soundtrack?	Recording & mix

1. Service [PARENT]

Definition

The institutional and organizational dimension of AD quality; concerning the conditions under which AD is commissioned ([COMMISSIONING AND PROCUREMENT](#)), made discoverable ([ACCESS-TO-ACCESS](#)), supplemented with complementary access formats ([PRE-SHOW ACCESS](#) + [AUGMENTED ACCESS](#)), and evaluated for quality ([QUALITY ASSURANCE](#)). Quality of service provision is the responsibility of commissioners (e.g., venues, broadcasters, platforms, distributors) and service providers (e.g., access companies, translation companies, production companies), rather than the describer or vocal talent. It precedes all craft-level quality decisions, and its failures cannot be remedied by a well-written script or a skilled delivery.

Scope

SERVICE encompasses everything that determines whether AD reaches users and whether the overall surrounding access package meets expectations. It is categorically distinct from how descriptions are written ([SCRIPT](#)), how they are performed ([VOICE](#)) and how the final audio product is technically assembled ([SOUND](#)). Items belong in SERVICE when the subject is institutional—what an organization provides, enables, procures, or oversees—rather than an individual (e.g., describer).

Data grounding

The data supports a five-child structure under **SERVICE** (17.8% of all codes):

1. **COMMISSIONING AND PROCUREMENT** (138 items, 5.1%¹): institutional commissioning of access;
2. **ACCESS-TO-ACCESS** (69 items, 2.5%): discoverability and usability of AD service itself;
3. **PRE-SHOW ACCESS** (77 items, 3.4%): pre-show supplementary access materials (60 items on **AUDIO INTRODUCTION** and 15 on **TOUCH TOUR**);
4. **AUGMENTED ACCESS** (57 items, 2.1%): augmented access formats that restructure the soundtrack (35 items on **AUDIO SUBTITLING** and 21 on **EXTENDED DESCRIPTION**);
5. **QUALITY ASSURANCE** (123 items, 4.5%): quality review processes (16 **COMPLIANCE** items, 62 **CONSULTATION** items, and 26 **FEEDBACK** items).

SERVICE cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
COMMISSIONING AND PROCUREMENT	How AD is acquired, planned, integrated into content provision?	Procurement & planning
ACCESS-TO-ACCESS	Is the AD service itself accessible, discoverable, and usable?	Discoverability & usability
PRE-SHOW ACCESS	What access is offered before viewing?	Audio intro, pre-show support
AUGMENTED ACCESS	How is the AD format extended/restructured to provide richer access?	Audio subtitling & extended AD
QUALITY ASSURANCE	How is the quality of the AD monitored, evaluated, and improved?	Quality review processes

1.1. Commissioning and procurement_[CHILD]

Definition

The institutional processes by which access to AD is acquired, planned, and integrated into content provision as a component of media or live event delivery. **COMMISSIONING** involves **PROCUREMENT** decisions, contractual obligations, access continuity across content series, customization options offered to users, and the proactive promotion of AD provision by distributors and content owners.

¹ As a percentage of all codes concerning **AD QUALITY DIMENSIONS**. Note on overlapping counts: Some items legitimately address multiple dimensions (e.g., an item about genre-appropriate vocabulary touches both **LANGUAGE/LEXICON** and **SKOPOS/SOURCE**). The percentages therefore sum to more than 100%.

Scope

COMMISSIONING in this framework is broader than **PROCUREMENT** and meeting quotas, insofar as it captures the idea that access should be embedded into content planning from the outset—not retrofitted after production—and that high-quality **COMMISSIONING** includes refreshing AD for updated content, maintaining consistency across episodes and series, offering personalization options (such as volume controls or format choices), and actively promoting AD availability to potential users and content partners, and selecting appropriate voice talent to perform the AD (**VOCAL CASTING**). It also manages the quality expectations built into those contracts.

Inclusion criteria

- Procurement of AD services (contracts, tenders, budgets)
- Selection of voice talent to perform AD (see **VOCAL CASTING** grandchild)
- Institutional responsibility for making AD available across content catalogues
- Access continuity (ensuring all episodes or instalments are described, not just pilots)
- Customization and personalization options offered at the service level
- Advocacy/promotion of AD by platforms or content owners to partners/providers
- Quota obligations and their institutional management
- Policies that treat access as integral to content acquisition or **COMMISSIONING**

Examples

"Customisation options may add complexity to the user interface and so we encourage providers to ensure such services are easy to use by disabled audiences. The use of default or automatic settings (where accessibility requirements are remembered) may help with this." (Ofcom, 2024a)

"Providers should make every effort to ensure that planned access services are added to ondemand programmes as soon as it is made available, particularly for popular programmes including boxsets." (Ofcom, 2024a)

"Consider evangelizing audio descriptions to your content providers so more video content has audio descriptions." (Apple, n.d.)

1.1.1. Vocal casting^[GRANDCHILD]

Definition

The institutional decision about which voice talent(s) to hire for AD performance, including selection based on vocal characteristics (accent, timbre, gender, age), appropriateness to the content (genre, tone, audience), distinguishability from other voices in the production, and continuity across episodes or series. **VOCAL CASTING** quality concerns whether

commissioners and producers select voice talent whose characteristics suit the program and audience, not whether the selected talent performs well (which is **VOICE**).

VOCAL CASTING is a **SERVICE**-level decision made by commissioners, producers, service providers before performance occurs. It addresses questions like: Should we hire a voice with a British or American accent? Should the narrator be male, female, or non-binary? Do we need multiple voice talents for audio subtitling? Should we maintain the same narrator across all episodes? These are institutional procurement decisions analogous to hiring a translator or casting an actor—they belong in **SERVICE** (**COMMISSIONING AND PROCUREMENT**), not in **VOICE** (which evaluates how well the hired talent performs).

Inclusion criteria

- Selection or hiring of voice talent
- Decisions about voice characteristics for casting (accent, gender, age, timbre)
- Matching voice type to program content or audience
- Choosing distinguishable voices for multiple narrators (e.g., for audio subtitling)
- Continuity decisions (same narrator across series/episodes)
- Appropriateness of voice selection for genre or target audience
- Adding additional voice talent for specific purposes (foreign language, character voices)
- Criteria for selecting voice talent

Examples

"Choose voice talents whose style and delivery (voice, pitch, and timbre) are distinguishable from other voices in a production without being unnecessarily distracting." [DCMP, n.d.]

"The accent of the voice actor should reflect the predominant accent in the program (for example, American English vs British English; Castilian Spanish vs Mexican Spanish, etc.)." (Netflix, 2023)

"It became clear that a gender- and age appropriate AST voice would intensify and improve the experience of a movie or TV series greatly. Especially the gender of the voice was frequently discussed, although there seemed to be no overarching preference in what gender a voice should have in a given scene. Participants rather demanded that the gender should fit the original speaker in the scene" (Scholz, 2021)

1. 2. Access-to-access^[CHILD]

Definition

The discoverability, usability, and navigability of the AD service itself—that is, the degree to which blind and partially sighted users can find, activate, and access AD without

encountering barriers at the interface or delivery level. [ACCESS-TO-ACCESS](#) is thus a meta-accessibility concern: it addresses whether the access service itself is accessible.

Scope

[ACCESS-TO-ACCESS](#) is established in the accessibility literature (Fryer, 2021) to describe situations in which a nominally available access service is unreachable due to inaccessible interfaces, inadequate labelling, unsuitable devices, or absent metadata thereof. A [SERVICE](#) can be commissioned, technically delivered but fail at the [ACCESS-TO-ACCESS](#) level, if, for example, the AD option is buried in a menu that screen readers cannot navigate, the AD track is not labelled in program listings, or the dedicated headset device is the only delivery option available. This node captures that gap.

Inclusion criteria

- Labelling and signposting of AD in user interfaces, apps, and program listings
- Discoverability of AD tracks within platforms, streaming services, or venues
- Usability of delivery services (headsets, receivers, dedicated hardware)
- Accessibility of the interface used to enable or disable AD
- Compatibility with assistive technologies (e.g., screen readers, voice control)
- Default enabling of AD for users who have indicated a preference system-wide
- Navigation to AD settings within apps or platforms
- Metadata standards that make AD-enabled content findable

Examples

"Your app should still enable audio descriptions by default when detecting the systemwide audio descriptions setting." (Apple Inc., n.d.)

"We encourage providers to ensure that the availability of audio introductions or extended AD is clearly signposted to audiences." (Ofcom, 2024a)

"It is important to have a choice when to listen and the device should be easily operated. Some people need better soundproof or noise-filtering headphones to be able to hear both the audio narrator and the stage performance. (D.N.) I would recommend a device that can enable a rewind to hear again if we missed anything, or to slow the speech. . . . Some people miss things due to challenging noises from the stage. (T.L.)" (Ferziger et al., 2020)

1. 3. Pre-show access^[CHILD]

Definition

Supplementary access materials provided before the main event, screening, or program begins, which give blind and partially sighted users contextual, narrative, or experiential information that enriches their understanding and enjoyment of the content.

PRE-SHOW ACCESS materials function as a preparatory layer of the access package, enabling end-users to arrive at the main content with greater background knowledge and sensory familiarity.

Inclusion criteria

- Any access material intended to be used before the main performance, screening, or broadcast
- Verbal or written content providing plot summaries, character introductions, or contextual background
- Haptic or tactile familiarization with physical elements of the production
- Pre-recording of cast voices or environmental sounds to orient users
- Combined or “packaged” approaches offering multiple pre-show formats together

Examples

"The auditory narration, touch tour, and pre-show notes can be viewed as a three-pronged 'AD package', varying the conventional medium through which theater information is conveyed and aiming to improve comprehension and enjoyment of the performance." (Ferziger et al., 2020)

1. 3. 1. Audio introduction [GRANDCHILD]

Definition

A recorded or live verbal presentation delivered before the main content begins, providing blind and partially sighted users with scene-setting information such as plot synopsis, character descriptions, cast information, and contextual background. **AUDIO INTRODUCTIONS** may be delivered via headset at the venue, made available for home listening in advance, or incorporated into streaming platform previews.

Inclusion criteria

- Recorded audio files made available before the performance or program
- Live verbal introductions delivered at the venue prior to the event
- Written pre-show notes designed to be read or listened to in advance
- Content covering: plot summary, character introduction, cast list, setting description, historical or contextual background
- Formats described as “audio introduction,” “pre-show notes,” “pre-show recording” or “verbal introduction”

Examples

"The provision of an AI could be one benchmark of a good quality description. Its purpose is to provide context and more detail than time allows during the dynamic AD." (Fryer, 2019)

"Audio describers typically include a statement in the Audio Introduction about the diversity of the cast, in order to present the breadth of the production. Many emphasised that they tend to keep this statement short and succinct, rather than dwelling on individual differences – in other words, they are seeking to capture the essence of incidental, integrated casting." (Thompson et al., 2020)

1.3.2. Touch tour^[grandchild]

Definition

A pre-event access activity where blind and partially sighted audience members are invited to physically handle props, costumes, set elements, or scale models in order to develop haptic familiarity with the physical world of the production before it begins. **TOUCH TOURS** may also include opportunities to hear cast members' voices and meet the audio describer, supporting character recognition during the performance.

Inclusion criteria

- Guided tactile exploration of physical production elements (props, costumes, set)
- Handling of scale models, replicas, or 3D-printed representations of elements
- Haptic familiarization activities described as "touch tour" or "tactile exploration"
- Opportunities to meet actors and hear their voices before the performance
- Combined sensory activities integrating tactile and auditory elements

Examples

"Touch tours are usually given to groups of B/VI individuals prior to the beginning of a play, and they include a tactile exploration of props, scenery, and stage-layout, as well as an opportunity to meet the actors and auditory describer and gain familiarity with their voices." (Ferziger et al., 2020)

1.4. Augmented access^[child]

Definition

Access formats that extend or restructure the relationship between the AD and the original soundtrack, going beyond standard narrated description to provide richer or more differentiated auditory access. **AUGMENTED ACCESS** formats involve either adding distinct voices

for foreign-language dialogue (**AUDIO SUBTITLING**) or manipulating the original media's temporal flow to create space for detailed description (**EXTENDED DESCRIPTION**). Both sub-formats share the defining characteristic that they require additional technical and human resources beyond the standard AD track.

Scope

Both **AUDIO SUBTITLING** and **EXTENDED DESCRIPTION** serve users whose access needs exceed what standard narrated AD can provide within a natural audio space. For instance, **AUDIO SUBTITLING** addresses multilingual content where the spoken original is inaccessible; **EXTENDED DESCRIPTION** addresses visually dense content where natural pauses are insufficient. Both require the service provider to make additional investment decisions, and both alter the user's experience of the original audio beyond what a describer's narration alone can achieve.

Inclusion criteria

- Any AD format that departs from the standard model of narration inserted into natural pauses
- Formats requiring manipulation of the original audio or temporal structure
- Formats requiring additional voice talent beyond the primary narrator
- Items discussing the rationale for choosing augmented over standard AD

Examples

"Adopting additional means of making programmes more accessible to people with sight loss and blind people, such as use of integrated descriptions, audio introductions and audio/spoken subtitles (see Audio Description section for more information)." (Ofcom, 2024a)

1. 4. 1. Audio subtitling^[grandchild]

Definition

The practice of voicing on-screen text (subtitles, foreign-language dialogue) as a spoken component of the AD track, typically using one or more additional voice talents distinct from the primary narrator. **AUDIO SUBTITLING** ensures that textual or foreign-language content visible to sighted viewers—but inaccessible to blind or partially sighted users—is rendered in an auditory form.

Inclusion criteria

- Voicing of on-screen subtitles as speech
- Use of additional voice talent(s) to differentiate spoken characters or foreign-language speakers
- Discussion of how to differentiate the narrator's voice from voiced subtitle content (e.g., via intonation change, earcons, or explicit framing)

- Decisions about when audio subtitling is required (e.g., multilingual films, films with more than a threshold number of subtitles)
- Voice credits and on-screen text

Examples

"In the case of subtitled films, the subtitles need to be voiced and turned into what is called Audio Subtitles (AST)." (Remael et al., 2015)

"If there are more than 10 subtitles, it might be necessary to add an additional voice talent to help differentiate the speakers." (Prime Video, 2024)

"Choose voice talents whose style and delivery (voice, pitch, and timbre) are distinguishable from other voices in a production without being unnecessarily distracting." (DCMP, n.d.)

1. 4. 2. Extended description [grandchild]

Definition

A format where original media is temporarily paused or slowed to allow longer, more detailed description than the natural audio pauses would accommodate. EXTENDED DESCRIPTION is used for pre-recorded content with visually complex scenes where information essential to comprehension cannot be conveyed within available gaps. It requires deliberate technical intervention to alter the media's timeline.

Inclusion criteria

- Discussion of pausing, freezing, or slowing original media to insert description
- Decision-making about when extended description is warranted
- Limitations of extended description
- User preferences for or against extended description
- Provision of extra or supplementary description content beyond what fits in pauses
- References to "expanded description" or "extended description" as a format

Examples

"Expanded description pauses the production automatically at certain points to allow for a more in-depth description of the content." (DCMP, n.d.)

"Expanded description is only an option for pre-recorded programs, since live events and broadcasts cannot be 'paused' to allow more detailed description." (DCMP, n.d.)

"In order to provide more action description would require compromising descriptions of other elements or having an extended description option where viewers could find more information online or as extra information on DVD." (Naraine et al., 2018)

"Viewers' desire for extended AD and extra content information was not specific to *Death Comes to Town*, but was found across different types of programming." (Naraine et al., 2018)

1.5. Quality assurance^[CHILD]

Definition

The systematic process by which the quality of AD—as a service and a product—is monitored, evaluated, and improved. **QUALITY ASSURANCE (QA)** in this framework involves three distinct but related activities:

1. **COMPLIANCE**: measuring conformance against established standards;
2. **CONSULTATION**: involving relevant expertise and user perspectives *during* production;
3. **FEEDBACK**: Gathering evaluative responses from users and clients *after* delivery.

Inclusion criteria

- Any process described as quality control, quality check, or quality review
- Evaluation frameworks, rubrics, or protocols for assessing AD quality
- Workflow descriptions that include a review or checking stage
- Items discussing who is responsible for **QA** and at which stage

Examples

"From a company management perspective, quality assurance "refers to any planned and systematic activity directed toward providing consumers with products (goods and services) of appropriate quality, along with the confidence that products meet consumers' requirements" (Evans & Lindsay, 2014: 12)." (Hermosa-Ramírez, 2022)

1.5.1. Compliance^[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **QA** concerned with verifying that AD meets established external standards, regulatory requirements, institutional guidelines, and industry benchmarks.

Inclusion criteria

- Adherence to named standards, codes of practice, or guidelines (e.g., Ofcom, DCMP, ADLAB, etc.)
- Regulatory obligations, quota **COMPLIANCE** (broadcast AD quotas, Ofcom mandates)
- Use of standards as evaluative benchmarks for assessing AD quality
- Certification, accreditation, or formal quality verification processes
- Discussion of what constitutes the minimum required quality level

- Items citing “golden rules,” mandatory requirements, or statutory obligations

Examples

"Regardless of the technologies used, we remind broadcasters that we expect access services to be high quality in order to contribute towards the statutory quotas." (Ofcom, 2024a)

"...professional AD often must also conform to non-public company style guides ([74] is a rare publicized exception), which adapt best practices to specific requirements, such as (dis)allowed terminology or bespoke standards for describing logos. Some style guides may also dictate the precise language used for describing certain character attributes or actions, or specify how to handle culturally specific references." (Bennett et al., 2025)

1. 5. 2. Consultation^[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **QA** concerned with involving relevant experts—particularly blind and partially sighted users, disability advisors, and peer colleagues—at one or more stages of the AD development process, in order to improve quality through formative input before or during production. **CONSULTATION** is prospective and process-oriented: it asks whether the right expertise was engaged at the right time.

Inclusion criteria

- Formative evaluation by blind and partially sighted consultants before AD is made publicly available
- Peer review of scripts by experienced describers
- Co-production models involving blind and partially sighted collaborators
- Voice talent participation in script quality checking
- Community advisory involvement in shaping AD approaches
- References to “nothing about us without us” principles applied to AD production
- Expert advisory roles in genre-specific AD (museums, dance, opera)

Examples

"Formative evaluation is an essential aspect of any visual art AD project. In AccesArte, it allowed us to incorporate BPS consultants into the process, improve the AD quality, and enrich the learning experience of the interns." (Colmenero & Gallego, 2023)

"Successful advancement in accessibility and inclusion requires the active involvement of visually impaired people from the very beginning and throughout a project, as stressed in the UNCRPD. Nothing about us, without us." (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

1. 5. 3. Feedback_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **QA** concerned with collecting evaluative responses from users and clients after AD has been delivered, in order to inform ongoing quality improvement. **FEEDBACK** is retrospective and summative: it asks how those who received the AD evaluated it, and whether that evaluation is systematically gathered and acted upon.

Inclusion criteria

- Post-delivery questionnaires, surveys, ratings from blind and partially sighted users or general audiences
- Client evaluation of completed AD deliverables
- Complaint mechanisms and their outcomes
- Structured audience feedback gathered as part of **QA** workflow
- User preference data used to guide future **COMMISSIONING** or production decisions

Examples

"Turning to end-user feedback as a QC measure, 24% of the respondents report including the feedback from blind and visually impaired consultants in their QC workflow." (Hermosa-Ramírez, 2022)

"Most notably, the respondents suggested a direct correlation between AD quality and the involvement of other stakeholders (namely, peer review of AD scripts, QC by the voice talents, by the client and by blind and visually impaired consultants)." (Hermosa-Ramírez, 2022)

2. Script_[PARENT]

Definition

The craft dimension of AD quality, concerning the writing of the description itself: **what** to describe (**CONTENT**), **how** to phrase it (**LANGUAGE**), **when** to fit it into soundtrack (**TIMING**), and **which** purpose it serves (**SKOPOS**) relative to the source text and target users. **SCRIPT** quality is the responsibility of the describer, and it involves all the decisions made at the scriptwriting stage—before vocal delivery and before technical production.

Scope

SCRIPT encompasses everything that is the direct responsibility and agency of the describer. It is strictly distinct from **SERVICE** (institutional provision of access), **VOICE** (vocal performance of the script), and **SOUND** (audio engineering of the final product).

Data grounding

The data supports a four-child structure under **SCRIPT** (70.7% of all items):

- a. **CONTENT** (1,029 items, 38%): what information to describe (**RELEVANCE**: 548 items), whether it is accurate (**ACCURACY**: 184), adequate (**ADEQUACY**: 193), and coherent (**COHERENCE**: 98);
- b. **LANGUAGE** (464 items, 17.1%): how to express descriptions linguistically (**LEXICON**: 193, **GRAMMAR**: 82; **COHESION**: 84; **STYLE**: 86);
- c. **TIMING** (199 items, 7.3%): when to place descriptions in the audio stream (**PLACEMENT**: 110) and whether they arrive at the right moment relative to the events they describe (**SYNCHRONY**: 69);
- d. **SKOPOS** (221 items, 8.1%): fitness-for-purpose relative to source and target (**SOURCE**: 134 items on genre/tone fidelity; **TARGET**: 78 items on user needs).

SCRIPT cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
CONTENT	What to describe?	Relevance, accuracy, adequacy, coherence
LANGUAGE	How to express it?	Lexicon, grammar, cohesion, style
TIMING	When to place it?	Placement, duration, synchronization
SKOPOS	Is it fit-for-purpose?	Genre/tone fidelity, user needs

Inter-child relationships and coding priorities

When items touch multiple children

CONTENT ↔ LANGUAGE

If about **what** information to convey → CONTENT

If about **how** to express that information → LANGUAGE

Example: "Describe actions using dynamic verbs" touches both; code based on emphasis

CONTENT ↔ TIMING

If about selection/adequacy decisions → CONTENT

If about temporal placement/duration → TIMING

Example: "Not enough time to describe everyone" primarily about CONTENT (**ADEQUACY** constrained by time)

LANGUAGE ↔ SKOPOS

If about linguistic quality per se → LANGUAGE

If about fitness of language to genre/audience → SKOPOS

Example: "Use simple vocabulary for children" → SKOPOS (TARGET)

Example: "Use vivid vocab." → LANGUAGE (LEXICON) unless explicitly tied to genre

CONTENT ↔ SKOPOS

If about selection/ACCURACY decisions → CONTENT

If about appropriateness to purpose → SKOPOS

Example: "Prioritize action in horror films" → SKOPOS (SOURCE) as it's genre-driven

TIMING ↔ SKOPOS

Rare overlap; code based on whether timing decision is driven by genre/audience needs

General rule

Code to the child that represents the primary concern of the item.
Use secondary coding when both are genuinely and equally relevant.

Coding workflow for script items

Step 1: Identify the primary question the item addresses

What to describe? → CONTENT

How to express it? → LANGUAGE

When to place it? → TIMING

Is it fit-for-purpose? → SKOPOS

Step 2: Within that child, identify the grandchild

Use the diagnostic questions provided in each grandchild definition

Step 3: Check for legitimate secondary codes

Does the item EQUALLY address a second dimension?

If yes, add secondary code with rationale

If no, resist the urge to over-code

Step 4: For ambiguous items

Consult the boundary case notes

Apply diagnostic questions

When genuinely unclear, flag for consensus discussion

Default to the dimension that seems most emphasized

2.1. Content_[CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **SCRIPT** quality concerning *what* elements to describe (**RELEVANCE**), *whether* adequate detail is provided (**ADEQUACY**), *whether* the information is accurate (**ACCURACY**), *whether* the descriptions are logically organized and internally consistent across the script and stimuli (**COHERENCE**).

Scope

CONTENT concerns everything about the informational substance of the description: what gets included, what gets emphasized, whether there is enough (or not too much) description, whether it is accurate, and whether it hangs together coherently. It does NOT concern how that content is expressed (**LANGUAGE**), when it is temporally placed (**TIMING**), or whether it is fit-for context (**SKOPOS**). Content is the describer's answer to: "What should the audience know, and in what order?"

Children of **CONTENT** represent the four questions describers ask about informational substance:

- a. **RELEVANCE**: Is the description relevant?
- b. **ADEQUACY**: Is it enough (but not too much)?
- c. **ACCURACY**: Is it factually correct?
- d. **COHERENCE**: Does it hang together with stimuli and logically?

CONTENT cheat sheet

Grandchild	Question	Focus
RELEVANCE	What to describe?	Selection & prioritization of visual information
ACCURACY	Is it correct?	Factual correctness & observational precision
ADEQUACY	Is it enough?	Sufficiency & appropriateness of detail
COHERENCE	Does it hang together?	Logical organization & consistency

2.1.1. Relevance_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of content quality concerned with selecting which audiovisual information warrants description among competing elements when time and attention is limited; it asks whether a piece of information should be described at all. The data shows that **RELEVANCE** is the most-discussed dimension of **CONTENT** (548 items).

RELEVANCE decisions are guided by multiple, sometimes competing criteria:

- **Narrative significance:** Does this advance the plot, develop character, or set the scene?
- **Perceptual salience:** Would a sighted viewer notice this?
- **Aural redundancy:** Is this already conveyed by dialogue or sound effects?

Inclusion criteria

- Discussion of what should or should not be described
- Statements about which visual elements warrant description
- Prioritization of information types (e.g., action vs. setting; plot vs. appearance)
- Decisions about narrative significance, importance, or essentiality
- Discussion of what can be omitted, deferred, or left implicit
- Guidance on focusing attention (what viewers “need to know”)
- Information hierarchies (e.g., “action first, then appearance if time allows”)
- Selection principles (e.g., “describe what is plot-critical, avoid redundancy with soundtrack”)

Examples

“The starting point for audio description is the identification of what to describe, such as information about who is in the scene, who is speaking, the setting and the scene, entries and exits, the ambiance, the lighting, dominant colour themes, costumes, physical attributes of the characters.” (Erkazancı-Durmuş & Okyayuz, 2023)

“Describe what is most essential for the viewer to know in order to follow, understand, and appreciate the intended learning outcomes of the program (such as actions and details that would confuse or mislead the audience if omitted) in the time allowed.” (DCMP, n.d.)

“A working definition of relevance was discussed in the workshops with describers, whereby ‘an outcome would be different if a piece of information was omitted. It might disadvantage our users in their understanding or engagement with the production.’” (Thompson et al., 2020)

2.1.2. Accuracy^[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **CONTENT** quality concerned with the factual correctness/fidelity, observational precision, and truth-value of descriptions. **ACCURACY** asks: Does the description correspond to the visual reality? Are spatial relationships correctly identified? Are observable details faithfully reported? Are facts distinguished from interpretations? **ACCURACY** is adherence to truth: what is described must match what is visible. Although **ACCURACY** might seem straightforward—“describe what you see”—the data reveals significant complexity. The 184 **ACCURACY** items span a spectrum from unambiguous factual errors (e.g., describing three people as two) to more nuanced questions about the boundary between observation and interpretation.

The two interlinked levels of **ACCURACY** are:

- **Factual accuracy:** Observable facts correctly reported (e.g., spatial positions, numbers, colors)
- **Objectivity:** Distinguishing what can be seen from what must be inferred

Objectivity is particularly complex. Is it “accurate” to describe a facial expression as “angry” when anger is an emotional state, not a directly observable visual property? The data shows this is where **ACCURACY** intersects with **STYLE**: some traditions of AD emphasize strict **Objectivity** (e.g., “furrowed brow”), while others permit limited interpretation when it serves comprehension (e.g., “angry expression”). This tension is also captured in **STYLE** items discussing objectivity, subjectivity, and the limits of “factual” description.

Inclusion criteria

- Factual correctness of descriptions
- Absence of errors in observation or reporting
- Correct identification of spatial relationships (e.g., left/right, up/down, near/far)
- Precision in describing observable details (e.g., colors, numbers, positions, sizes)
- Avoidance of misidentification or misreporting
- Correspondence between description and visual reality
- Discussion of objectivity vs. subjectivity
- Distinguishing observable facts from inferences or interpretations
- Correcting errors or avoiding mistakes
- Faithfulness to what is actually visible

Examples

“Accurate: Descriptions are factually correct and error-free.” (Do et al., 2026)

“Accuracy in AD includes the possibility not only of misnaming something or using an inappropriate verb (saying someone walks when they run), but also of a false addition (saying something happens when it doesn’t) and omission.” (Fryer, 2019)

2.1.3. Adequacy_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **CONTENT** quality concerned with whether the description provides sufficient detail and depth for audience comprehension and engagement without overwhelming with excessive or unnecessary information. **ADEQUACY** asks: Is there enough information to form mental representation? Is the level of detail appropriate? **ADEQUACY** operates at a different level than **RELEVANCE**. Where **RELEVANCE** asks “should this be described?,” **ADEQUACY** asks “given that it’s been selected, is the description sufficient and not too dense?” A describer might identify that a character’s look is relevant but then provide inadequate detail (“a woman enters” vs.

"a woman in her sixties, wearing a lab coat, with short grey hair, enters"). Conversely, a describer might provide excessive details where less would suffice, creating cognitive overload. The data (193 items) shows recurring user complaints about "vague" descriptions and practitioner guidance to "pay attention to detail," indicating **ADEQUACY** is a persistent quality concern.

ADEQUACY encompasses three related concerns:

- **Sufficiency:** Is there enough detail to understand/visualize?
- **Specificity:** Is the description concrete or vague?
- **Proportionality:** Is the amount of detail matched to the element's perceived importance?

Inclusion criteria

- Discussion of whether enough information is provided
- Complaints about vagueness, sparseness, or insufficient detail
- Praise for thoroughness, completeness, or comprehensive coverage
- Discussion of level of detail (general vs. specific, abstract vs. concrete)
- References to "sufficient," "adequate," "complete," "thorough," "detailed"
- Discussion of information gaps or missing elements
- Statements about "more information needed" or "too much information"
- Balance between brevity and elaboration
- Appropriate depth of treatment for different elements

Examples

"...the audio describers accentuate that the denseness (i.e. the wordiness and the information load) of an AD text needs to be guided by the original product." (Erkazanci-Durmuş & Okyayuz, 2023)

"Around 33% of participants preferred as little AD as possible to gain an objective understanding and prevent cognitive overload. Few wanted extremely detailed descriptions, and most favored something in the middle." (Jiang & Zhu, 2021)

2.1.4. Coherence_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **CONTENT** quality concerned with logical organization, internal consistency, and narrative unity of descriptions across a production. **COHERENCE** asks: Do descriptions hang together as a unified text? Is information logically sequenced? Are character names and terminology used consistently? Does a narrative thread connect individual descriptions into a comprehensible whole? **COHERENCE** is what transforms a series of isolated descriptions into a

story. Where **RELEVANCE**, **ADEQUACY**, and **ACCURACY** concern the quality of individual descriptions, **COHERENCE** concerns the relationships between descriptions.

The two realizations of **COHERENCE** are:

- **Sequence** (organization, logical order): Information is conveyed in a logical sequence that supports comprehension. This includes **Spatial Sequencing** (e.g., foreground vs. background), **Temporal Sequencing** (chronological), **Importance-based Sequencing** (most significant first), and **Perceptual Sequencing** (what viewers notice first).
- **Consistency** (terminological, stylistic): The same character is called by the same name throughout; vocabulary choices remain stable.

Important distinction from **LANGUAGE** → **COHESION**

- **COHERENCE**_[CONTENT] = logical organization and conceptual unity
- **COHESION**_[LANGUAGE] = linguistic devices that link sentences (conjunctions, pronouns, demonstratives)

A description can be cohesive (e.g., using "he... then he... as he..." to link sentences) but incoherent (i.e., if the actions described do not follow a logical order). Conversely, a description can be coherent (i.e., logically organized) but lack cohesive devices. In practice, good AD achieves both.

Inclusion criteria

- Logical organization or structure of information
- Sequencing (what to describe first, what follows)
- Consistency of character names or terminology across the script
- Narrative flow or continuity
- Maintenance of a "narrative thread"
- Avoidance of contradictions or inconsistencies
- Smooth transitions between descriptions or scenes
- Temporal, spatial, or causal links between described elements
- Consistency of descriptive approach or style
- Overall unity of the AD text

Examples

"The effect of describing the clothes in the middle of an exciting action sequence, makes it funny and therefore inappropriate, which should not be the intention." (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

"The order of information in the sentence influences how easily it can be processed. Starting with known information in sentence-initial position provides the best framework for what follows, but starting with new information in sentence-initial position, on the other hand, can draw attention to a specific element." (Remael et al., 2015)

2.2. Language^[CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **SCRIPT** quality concerned with how descriptions are expressed: the vocabulary, grammatical structures, cohesive devices used to link the text, and stylistic register. **LANGUAGE** quality asks: Are the words well-chosen? Is the grammar correct? Do sentences connect? Is the manner of expression appropriate and effective?

Scope

LANGUAGE concerns everything about how descriptions are expressed in words. Accordingly, the four children of **LANGUAGE** capture major linguistic craft decisions: **LEXICON** (what words), **GRAMMAR** (what structures), **COHESION** (what links), **STYLE** (what voice/register).

LANGUAGE cheat sheet

Grandchild	Question	Focus
LEXICON	Are the words well-chosen?	Word choice
GRAMMAR	Is it grammatically correct?	Sentence structure
COHESION	Do sentences connect?	Linguistic linking
STYLE	Is the manner appropriate?	Register & manner

2.2.1. Lexicon^[grandchild]

Definition

The selection of individual words and phrases used in the description, including lexical richness, precision, concreteness, vividness, and appropriateness of terminology. **LEXICON** concerns whether the describer has chosen the right words—words that are specific rather than vague, concrete rather than abstract, evocative rather than flat, accessible rather than jargon-laden.

Inclusion criteria

- Word choice or word selection decisions
- Level of vocabulary (e.g., simple vs. complex, accessible vs. technical)
- Terminology decisions (e.g., technical items, specialized vocabulary)
- Concrete vs. abstract language
- Vivid, evocative, or descriptive word choices
- Precision or specificity of vocabulary
- Use of particular words or labels (e.g., color terms, adjectives)
- Avoidance of jargon or overly complex terms

Boundary case: naming cinematic technique

Platform guidance conflicts on whether describers may name film language, conceding only that terms long absorbed into common speech, such as “close-up,” may pass (Netflix, 2023; Prime Video, 2024). Perego (2015, p. 34) sets out three grades that are useful for coding: naming the technique (“now in close-up”); naming it and giving its function (“a close-up reflects the fear in her eyes”); and rendering the function alone (“fear is reflected in her eyes”). The choice turns on what the technique contributes to meaning and style within the work, not on whether its label is technical. Code the item to **LEXICON** when the concern is the word choice itself, and to **SKOPOS** when it is tied to the aesthetic significance of the technique for that particular work.

Examples

“SD should also avoid using adjectives to create a speculative description which could lead to different personal interpretation among the audience.” (Natalie et al., 2021b)

“When describing the height of the church and its surface, it is always advisable to use descriptive metaphors, similes and analogies with objects that the intended audience is familiar with from everyday life. For example, instead of saying that a church is one hundred square metres, the describer might say that ten bedrooms could easily fit in it: these strategies enable listeners to build up a sharper mental image of what is being described.” (Pacinotti, 2022)

“...using vivid and varied language including adjectives and adverbs that allow the audience to create its own image” (Tor-Carroggio & Vercauteren, 2020)

2.2.2. Grammar^[grandchild]

Definition

The correctness and effectiveness of grammatical constructions and sentence structures used in the description, including word order, verb tenses, use of articles, clause relationships, and syntactic complexity. **GRAMMAR** quality concerns whether the description is grammatically correct, whether sentence structures are clear, and whether syntactic choices support (rather than hinder) comprehension and engagement.

Inclusion criteria

- Grammatical correctness or errors
- Sentence structure (simple, compound, complex)
- Use of articles
- Verb tenses and aspect
- Active vs. passive voice
- Use of clauses and subordination

- Syntactic complexity or simplicity
- Grammatical consistency
- Morphological correctness
- Punctuation

Examples

"We use the definite article 'the', if the location, house or dwelling has already been introduced." (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

"Indirect speech seems quite effective, it reduces the number of extra voices and therefore of confusion, and it gives smoothness to the whole described film." (Perego, 2017)

2.2.3. Cohesion^[grandchild]

Definition

The use of linguistic devices that create inter-sentential connections and textual unity, including conjunctions, pronouns, demonstratives, ellipsis, and lexical cohesion. **COHESION** quality concerns whether descriptions are linguistically linked to create a flowing text rather than a series of disconnected sentences. **COHESION** operates at the discourse level, binding individual sentences into a unified narrative. More specifically, **COHESION** is a technical term from Halliday and Hasan's (1976) systemic functional linguistics, referring to the linguistic mechanisms that create texture. It is distinct from **COHERENCE** (under **CONTENT**), which refers to conceptual/logical unity. A text can be cohesive (using many linguistic links) but incoherent (illogical organization), or coherent (logically organized) but lacking cohesive devices.

The five types of **COHESION** according to Halliday and Hasan (1976) are:

- **Reference** (e.g., pronouns, demonstratives: "the woman," "she," "this")
- **Conjunction** (e.g., "and," "but," "because," "while," "then")
- **Ellipsis** (i.e., omission of repeated elements)
- **Substitution** (e.g., "one," "do," "so," etc.)
- **Lexical cohesion** (i.e., repetition, synonymy, collocation)

Inclusion criteria

- Use of conjunctions to link sentences or clauses
- Pronominal references (e.g., "he," "she," "they," "it," "this," "that")
- Demonstratives (e.g., "this," "that," "these," "those")
- Lexical repetition or synonym use for cohesion
- Elliptical constructions
- Temporal markers linking actions (e.g., "then," "meanwhile," "as," "while")
- Causal markers (e.g., "because," "so," "therefore")
- Any linguistic device creating inter-sentential connection

Examples

"...we decided not to eliminate the repetitions owing to the wide range of opinions, and also because this is an accessibility technique that seeks to promote understanding by reinforcing textual cohesion." (Luque & Soler, 2023)

"6.1 Avoid writing short sentences in a row: "He gets out of the car. He goes to the front door. A woman opens the door." Instead, "He gets out of the car and walks to the front door. A woman opens the door." (Prime Video, 2024)

2.2.4. Style_[grandchild]

Definition

The overall manner of expression and level of formality in the description, including narrative, voice, linguistic register (formal, informal, colloquial), tone (e.g., descriptive, narrative), and consistency of stylistic approach. **STYLE** concerns the describer's "textual voice." More specifically, **STYLE** concerns the decisions about how to say things that go beyond individual word choice or sentence grammar.

Some dimensions of **STYLE** include:

- **Register** (formal vs. informal language)
- **Narrative voice** (third-person neutral, first-person, impersonal constructions)
- **Tone** (detached, warm, institutional, conversational)

The data reveals an important stylistic distinction between **descriptive** and **narrative** approaches to AD.

Descriptive **STYLE** largely focuses on static observation, visual details, and spatial arrangement. It emphasizes the observable characteristics of things, what they look like, where they are positioned. **Descriptive** **STYLE** tends toward present-tense observation with minimal temporal linking: "A man stands by the window. He wears a grey suit. Rain falls outside."

Narrative **STYLE** focuses on storytelling flow, temporal progression, and dynamic action. It emphasizes causal/temporal relationships between actions and how events unfold. **Narrative** **STYLE** creates a story arc with linked events: "As rain begins to fall, a man in a grey suit approaches the window and gazes out at the street below."

The choice between these approaches affects:

- **COHESION**: **Narrative** **STYLE** typically uses more temporal and causal conjunctions.
- **GRAMMAR** (verb choice): **Descriptive** **STYLE** may use more stative verbs; narrative uses dynamic verbs.

- Flow: **Narrative** **STYLE** emphasizes the unfolding story; **Descriptive** **STYLE** emphasizes the visual scene.

Both approaches can be high quality; the choice depends on the content type, pacing, and intended effect. Some describers blend both within a single production.

Overall, **STYLE** is where individual describer's "signature" emerges—different describers can describe the same content with the same accuracy but in recognizably different styles.

Inclusion criteria

- Discussion of **descriptive** ("objective") and **narrative** (storytelling) styles
- Register or formality level (formal, informal, colloquial technical)
- Narrative perspective (third-person, first-person, impersonal)
- Tone or manner of expression (detached, warm, neutral, institutional)

Examples

"Style is the result of the word choice of authors, along with their choice of sentence structure and the appropriate use of figurative and idiomatic language." (Remael et al., 2015)

"Providers may wish to explore different approaches to AD styles, taking account of audience preferences and feedback along with the programme type. This could include adopting a more neutral or unobtrusive style or a more informal or subjective style, for example by incorporating humour that reflects the nature of the content. Audience preferences for styles of AD vary and so providers may wish to offer different styles for different programmes." (Ofcom, 2024a)

2.3. Timing [CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **SCRIPT** quality concerned with the temporal placement of descriptions relative to the original soundtrack and visual events. **TIMING** addresses when descriptions occur (**PLACEMENT**) and whether they align appropriately with the audiovisual content they describe (**SYNCHRONY**).

Scope

TIMING in pre-recorded AD is fundamentally a scriptwriting decision. The describer, during composition, decides:

- Which audio pauses to use for description
- Whether to use pre-description (describing before the visual event; Hyks & Blokland, 2023) or simultaneous description
- Whether to risk minimal overlap with dialogue for conveying critical information
- How to coordinate with sound effects and music

TIMING is a scriptwriting decision in pre-recorded AD, which is the vast majority of the dataset. In live AD it collapses into **VOICE**, where placement is settled in real time during performance.

TIMING cheat sheet

Grandchild	Question	Focus
PLACEMENT	When to insert?	Description cueing, gap selection, pre-vs post-description
SYNCHRONY	Does it align?	Visual alignment, synchronous vs. asynchronous delivery

2. 3. 1. Placement_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **TIMING** that concerns where in the audio stream a description is inserted, including which pauses to use (cueing) and whether the description avoids overlap with essential audio elements (dialogue, music, sound effects). **PLACEMENT** asks: Did the describer choose the right gap, and did the description stay within it without crashing into audio that audiences need to hear?

Inclusion criteria

- Discussion of when to insert descriptions
- Use of natural pauses or silent gaps in dialogue
- Avoiding overlap with dialogue or critical sound
- Overlap hierarchy when overlap is unavoidable (e.g., lyrics → insert in chorus)
- Cases where overlap is justified because the visual information outweighs the audio
- Strategic silence (choosing NOT to describe in a particular gap)

Examples

"AD for screen must not overlap dialogue or important sound effects, so the time to insert AD is considerably curtailed." (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

"AD is customarily 'inserted in nonsemantically meaningful pauses' to avoid overlap with dialogues or relevant music tracks (Arma 2011, 15), while short silent intervals between the dialogue and AD are preserved to aid film perception." (Kajzer-Wietrzny & Tymczyńska, 2015)

"...a detailed analysis of the individual AD scripts and the waveforms of the AD and the film sound revealed that novice ADs with high volume quality could be positioned in such a way that low-level environmental sounds could be heard." (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2024)

2.3.2. Synchrony^[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **TIMING** that concerns whether descriptions align with the visual events they describe—that is, whether the temporal relationship between description and on-screen action is appropriate. **SYNCHRONY** asks: Does description arrive at the right moment relative to the image, and does it preserve the narrative experience the production intends?

Inclusion criteria

- Synchronous or simultaneous description (describing events as they occur)
- Asynchronous or pre-/post-description (deliberate or problematic misalignment)
- Descriptions that arrive too early or late relative to events
- Preserving dramatic tension, suspense, or surprise through temporal alignment
- Coordination between the description's temporal position and visual narrative flow
- Evaluative statements about whether the AD was "successfully woven around the soundtrack" in the sense of matching the visual rhythm

Examples

"Voice descriptions as close to the action as possible. When time is limited, describe the images that are on the screen, although there may be times when leading the action (describing before the image appears) is necessary." (DCMP, n.d.)

"To ensure that the audience hears the environmental sound or the sound of the movements of the characters, the AD may be presented slightly faster or later than the timing of these movements. (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2024)

2.4. Skopos^[child]

Definition

The dimension of **SCRIPT** quality concerned with the fitness-for-purpose of the description, evaluated through the dual lens of fidelity to the source material (genre, tone, artistic intent) and adaptation to the target audience (user needs, cultural context). **SKOPOS**, from translation studies, recognizes that quality is not absolute but relational; a description is good insofar as it achieves its intended purpose with its intended audience while respecting the original work.

Scope

SKOPOS theory (Reiß & Vermeer, 1984/2014) from translation studies provides the theoretical foundation for understanding AD as a form of (inverse) intersemiotic translation (Díaz-Cintas, 2005; Jakobson, 1959/2021), translating the visual channel into the

verbal channel while maintaining functional equivalence (Nida 1964/2011). The quality of this translation depends on:

- **SOURCE** fidelity: Does the AD honor the original work's genre conventions, aesthetic choices, and intended effect? A horror film's AD should preserve suspense; a documentary's should maintain informational clarity; an art-house film's might embrace ambiguity.
- **TARGET** adaptation: Does the AD serve its users effectively? Children need different vocab. than adults; educational content requires different priorities than entertainment; cultural context affects what can be assumed vs. what must be explained.

The two grandchildren capture this dual orientation. **SOURCE** (loyalty to the original) and **TARGET** (service to users). These can sometimes conflict (e.g., preserving auteur ambiguity vs. ensuring user comprehension), requiring describers to make strategic choices.

SKOPOS cheat sheet

Grandchild	Question	Focus
SOURCE	Does it honor the artwork?	Fidelity to original
TARGET	Does it serve the audience?	Adaptation to users

2. 4. 1. Source_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **SKOPOS** concerned with fidelity to the original work's genre, tone, cinematic style, and artistic intent. **SOURCE**-oriented quality asks: Does the AD honor what this work is? Does it preserve genre conventions? Does it match the intended mood and aesthetic? **SOURCE** fidelity recognizes that AD is not imposed upon media but emerges *from* media, and should respect its **SOURCE** character.

As such, **SOURCE**-oriented quality involves several related concepts:

- **genre fidelity** (e.g., AD for horror should enhance suspense, not diffuse it; AD for comedy should preserve timing, not explain jokes)
- **auteur description** (some describers/commissioners advocate for AD that respects the director's vision and visual style)
- **film language preservation** (i.e., describing cinematographic choices [close-ups, lighting, color palettes when they're aesthetically significant])
- **tonal matching** (vocabulary and pacing that suit the source content, e.g., using stark language for noir, lyrical language for romance)

SOURCE orientation can conflict with **TARGET** orientation, preserving a film's deliberate ambiguity might confuse some users; honoring an experimental film's non-linear structure might challenge comprehension.

Inclusion criteria

- Matching AD style to program genre (documentary, drama, horror, comedy)
- Describing cinematic techniques when aesthetically significant
- Preserving the tone or mood of the original work
- Respecting auteur/director vision in AD approach
- Film language and visual style description
- Genre-appropriate vocabulary and pacing
- Honoring the source work's artistic intent

Examples

"An effective audio describer delivers the text in a tone that matches the programme material." (Orero, 2007)

"...comparable access is about translating the director's vision and style for the visuals of a show into an auditory equivalent..." (Naraine et al., 2018)

2. 4. 2. Target_[grandchild]

Definition

The dimension of **SKOPOS** concerned with adaptation to the target audience's needs, characteristics, and context. Target-oriented quality asks: Does the AD serve its users effectively? Is vocabulary appropriate for the audience's age and background? Is cognitive load managed? Are cultural assumptions explained? Does it respect disability etiquette? **TARGET**-orientation recognizes that AD exists for blind and partially sighted users and must prioritize their comprehension and dignity.

TARGET-oriented quality involves:

- **age appropriateness** (children need different vocabulary and pacing than adults)
- **knowledge assumption** (what can be assumed vs. what must be explained, e.g., cultural references, genre conventions)
- **educational adaptation** (when AD serves learning objectives, content must support those goals)
- **disability** etiquette (respectful representation; avoiding patronizing language; following community preferences)
- **cultural context** (explaining references that may be unfamiliar; adapting to cultural norms).

TARGET-orientation can conflict with **SOURCE**-orientation: explaining cultural references increases accessibility but may interrupt narrative flow; simplifying vocabulary serves young viewers but may dilute the source work's register.

Inclusion criteria

- Age-appropriate vocabulary and content (children vs. adults)
- Educational goals and learning outcomes
- Cultural context and reference explanation
- Disability etiquette and respectful representation
- Assumptions about audience knowledge/background
- User comprehension and accessibility prioritization
- Adaptation to audience sophistication level

Examples

"AD is ultimately a creative exercise, the concept of 'quality' must be subjectively assessed by users and will relate to expectations..." (Fryer & Walczak, 2021)

"A fundamental requirement for every audio describer is to know the target audience. Whom am I addressing? Who will benefit from this AD?" (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

3. Voice [PARENT]

Definition

The vocal execution of **SCRIPT**: how clearly sounds are articulated (**ARTICULATION**) and how effectively the voice performs the text through prosodic patterns, tonal quality, as well as expressive engagement (**PERFORMANCE**). **VOICE** quality is the responsibility of the voice talent, and it covers everything done during vocal performance—after the script is written and before the recording is technically integrated (**SOUND**).

Scope

VOICE concerns all aspects of vocal performance heard in recorded or live AD: the voice talent's execution of the script through speech. Items belong in **VOICE** when they concern how the script is vocally performed—pronunciation clarity, speaking pace, pitch patterns, vocal tone, and expressive quality. **VOICE** is distinct from **SCRIPT** (written before performance, concerning content, language, timing), from **SERVICE** (institutional provision, including quality assurance and vocal casting), and from **SOUND** (technical audio engineering after performance—mixing, volume, balance). If the quality concern is the voice talent's performance during recording or live description, it is **VOICE**; if it is what was written, it is **SCRIPT**; if it is institutional provision, including who was cast to speak, it is **SERVICE**; if it is the processing of audio, it is **SOUND**.

Data grounding

The data supports a two-child structure for **VOICE**: (7.2% of all items)

- a. **ARTICULATION** (32 items): clarity of sound production (16 **PRONUNCIATION** items and 14 **ENUNCIATION**/diction items).
- b. **PERFORMANCE** (150 items): effectiveness of vocal performance (87 **PROSODY** items covering 39 **INTONATION**, 4 **STRESS**, and 40 **PACE**; and 63 **AFFECT** items covering 8 **EUPHONY** and 55 **EMOTIVITY**)

VOICE cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
ARTICULATION	Can you understand the words?	Pronunciation & enunciation
PERFORMANCE	Is the voice effective, engaging, and appropriate?	Prosody & affect

3.1. Articulation_[CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **VOICE** quality concerned with the technical clarity and correctness of speech sound production. Articulation addresses whether individual sounds, words, and phrases are pronounced and enunciated clearly and correctly for the audience to understand what is being said. It is the foundational intelligibility layer of vocal performance: if articulation fails, the content cannot be received regardless of how well the **SCRIPT** is written or how expressively it is performed.

ARTICULATION operates at the segmental phonetic level—the production of individual speech sounds (consonants, vowels) and their combination into syllables and words. It is categorically distinct from suprasegmental features (**PROSODY**) which operate across segments.

The two grandchildren distinguish between:

- **PRONUNCIATION** = producing the correct sounds (i.e., saying “nuclear” not “nucular”)
- **ENUNCIATION** = producing sounds clearly; not mumbling, not slurring

3.1.1. Pronunciation_[grandchild]

Definition

The correctness of speech sound production, ensuring that words are produced with their accepted phonetic forms rather than with mispronunciation. **PRONUNCIATION** asks: Are words being said “right” according to standard or accepted usage? This encompasses correct

production of individual phonemes, appropriate stress placement within words, and culturally/linguistically appropriate sound patterns.

Inclusion criteria

- Correct vs. incorrect **PRONUNCIATION** of specific words
- Mispronunciation of names, places, or technical terms

Boundary case: accent

Accent requires a rule of its own. Branje and Fels (2012) identified a noticeable accent as a property shared by the lowest-rated describers, and reception studies routinely record accent as a component of vocal quality. Analytically, however, variation in accent is not a defect of **PRONUNCIATION**: an accented describer may produce every phoneme of their own variety correctly, and a low rating in this sense registers the listener's familiarity rather than a property of the **VOICE**. Pronunciation presupposes a reference variety against which correctness is measured, since there is no unaccented speech, only speech a listener hears as unaccented. The decision is in any case not the describer's: accent is settled at **VOCAL CASTING**, among the **COMMISSIONING** decisions of **SERVICE**. Code errors of phonetic form here; code judgments about which accent should have been engaged to **VOCAL CASTING**.

Examples

"Poor pronunciation can break the trust built between the describer and the AD user (Fryer, 2016), as well as potentially confuse the audience. For example, the describer pronouncing the name of a character or a location differently from the way the cast pronounces it can create a lack of coherence." (Fryer, 2019)

"[T]he narrator's voice and pronunciation are one of the critical factors impacting the market growth." (Peaty et al., 2023)

3. 1. 2. Enunciation**[grandchild]**

Definition

The clarity and distinctness of speech sound production, ensuring that sounds, syllables, and words are articulated with sufficient precision and separation for the audience to distinguish and understand them. **ENUNCIATION** quality asks: Can the audience clearly hear and understand what is being said? This includes clear consonant articulation, distinct vowel production, appropriate syllable separation, and avoiding mumbling, slurring, or running words together.

Inclusion criteria

- Diction (as clarity of speech)
- Clear vs. unclear speech production
- Clarity of consonant and vowel articulation

- Intelligibility of speech
- Complaints about difficulty understanding the narrator
- References to “clear speech,” “clear diction,” “crisp articulation”

Examples

“Clear expression of words.” (Ferziger et al., 2020)

“The voice is clear and easy to listen to.” (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2022)

3.2. Performance_[CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **VOICE** quality concerned with the expressive, prosodic, and tonal aspects of vocal execution—how effectively the voice performs the text beyond basic intelligibility. **PERFORMANCE** addresses whether pitch patterns are varied and appropriate (**PROSODY**) and whether the overall vocal character is pleasant and emotionally engaging (**AFFECT**). Where **ARTICULATION** asks “can you understand the words?,” **PERFORMANCE** asks “is the voice effective, engaging, and appropriate?”

PERFORMANCE concerns all suprasegmental and expressive features of the voice. It is where the voice talent brings the script to life (or fails to). A narrator can have perfect **ARTICULATION** but poor **PERFORMANCE** (monotone, emotionally flat, unpleasant timbre); equally, excellent **PERFORMANCE** but poor **ARTICULATION** (engaging and expressive but hard to understand).

The two grandchildren distinguish between:

- **PROSODY** = acoustic/phonetic patterns (pitch, stress, pace)—measurable features that operate across syllables and words
- **AFFECT** = overall expressiveness of the voice—impact of timbre and emotional engagement

3.2.1. Prosody_[grandchild]

Definition

The suprasegmental phonetic features of vocal delivery—patterns of pitch, stress, and pace that operate across syllables, words, and phrases. **PROSODY** quality concerns whether these patterns are varied, appropriate, and effective for the content and audience. **PROSODY** transforms a sequence of words into meaningful, engaging speech through melody (**INTONATION**), emphasis (**STRESS**), and temporal flow (**PACE**).

PROSODY is sometimes called the “melody” or “music” of speech. It includes three core components:

- **INTONATION** (pitch patterns): rising, falling, or level pitch across phrases; avoidance of monotone
- **STRESS** (emphasis): which words or syllables receive prominence through pitch, duration, or intensity
- **PACE** (rhythm/tempo): the speed and temporal patterning of speech

These three components work together to create the overall prosodic “shape” of the voice. Good **PROSODY** supports comprehension (e.g., rising pitch signals a question), maintains engagement (varied patterns prevent monotony), and matches the tone and genre of the content (e.g., calm pacing for a nature documentary, punchy pacing for action).

Examples

“...paralinguistic aspects such as segmentation and prosody (including intonation and pace) help to shape meaning...” (Fryer, 2019)

“They revealed high energy (high potency), high intensity (loud volume) and a rising pitch contour (vivid intonation). These acoustic features correlate with a confident and optimistic voice and, in psychological terms, they reveal a confident, extrovert and lively personality...” (Iglesias-Fernández et al., 2015)

3. 2. 1. 1. Intonation_[great-grandchild]

Definition

The patterns of pitch variation across syllables, words and phrases that create the melodic contour of speech. **INTONATION** quality concerns whether pitch patterns are appropriately varied (not monotone), whether they support meaning (e.g., rising for questions, falling for statements), and whether they engage the listener through melodic interest.

Inclusion criteria

- Pitch variation vs. monotone delivery
- Rising, falling, or level pitch contours
- Melodic patterns across phrases
- Vocal melody or musicality
- Flat vs. varied intonation

Examples

“...change in the tone of voice in order to create a distinction between reading text and the actual description...” (Netflix, 2023)

3.2.1.2. Stress^[great-grandchild]

Definition

The placement of emphasis on particular words, syllables, or phrases through increased pitch, duration or intensity. **STRESS** quality concerns whether emphasis is placed appropriately to support meaning, whether important information is highlighted, and whether **STRESS** patterns contribute to (rather than detract from) comprehension and engagement.

Inclusion criteria

- Emphasis on specific words or phrases
- Highlighting key information vocally
- Stress placement for meaning disambiguation
- Accentuation
- Vocal foregrounding
- Inappropriate or missing emphasis

Examples

"Who does what? If the description is recorded by a live voice, the pronoun 'he' can be stressed to make it clear who is carrying out the action." (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

3.2.1.3. Pace^[great-grandchild]

Definition

The rate of speech, typically measured in words per minute or perceived as fast, moderate, or slow tempo. **PACE** quality concerns whether the speaking rate is appropriate for audience comprehension, whether it matches the content's rhythm and mood, and whether it supports (rather than hinders) information processing.

Inclusion criteria

- Speaking rate or speed (words per minute)
- Too fast, too slow, too rushed, or leisurely delivery
- Tempo matching to program **PACE**
- Rate of speech for audience comprehension
- Rhythm or temporal flow of delivery
- Pausing patterns as part of pacing

Examples

"Racing through a lyrical love scene would be as inappropriate as describing a high-octane chase sequence at a snail's pace." (Fryer, 2019)

"Increasing the speech rate may provide more information and convey more details about the situation and may also solve issues with intonation." (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2022)

3.2.2. Affect^[grandchild]

Definition

The overall expressive nature of the voice, concerning both the pleasantness of vocal timbre (**EUPHONY**) and the degree of emotional engagement or expressiveness (**EMOTIVITY**). **AFFECT** is the subjective impression the voice makes on listeners: Does it sound pleasant? Is it engaging? Does it convey appropriate emotion? **AFFECT** is what turns a technically correct reading into an experience that is pleasant, engaging, and emotionally resonant.

AFFECT combines two related but distinguishable aspects:

- **EUPHONY** = the pleasantness, warmth, or appropriateness of the voice's timbre and tone
- **EMOTIVITY** = the emotional expressiveness, animation, or engagement conveyed

Together, these determine whether a **VOICE** is not just intelligible and prosodically competent, but also pleasant to listen to and emotionally engaging. A voice can be euphonious but emotionally flat (pleasant but boring), or emotively engaging but harsh (exciting but unpleasant). Both contribute to overall **AFFECT**.

3.2.2.1. Euphony^[great-grandchild]

Definition

The pleasantness of the voice's timbre and tonal quality. **EUPHONY** quality concerns whether the voice sounds pleasant rather than harsh, warm rather than cold, smooth rather than grating, and generally appropriate to the listener's experience. **EUPHONY** is about the inherent quality of the voice itself—its "color" or "texture"—independent of what it says or how expressively it says it.

Inclusion criteria

- Pleasant vs. unpleasant voice
- Warm, smooth, gentle, soft voice
- Harsh, grating, cold, aggressive voice
- Timbre or tonal quality descriptions
- "Tone of voice" when referring to pleasantness
- Voice that is "easy on the ears" or "difficult to listen to"
- Non-aggressive, non-intrusive voice quality

Examples

"...euphony or the quality of being pleasing to the ear, (assessed by the editor, the producer, and those describers who are voicing the recording)..." (Fryer, 2019)

3. 2. 2. 2. Emotivity_[great-grandchild]

Definition

The degree of emotional expressiveness, animation, and engagement conveyed through the voice. **EMOTIVITY** quality concerns whether the performance is emotionally appropriate and engaging (animated, warm, enthusiastic) rather than flat, lifeless, or robotic. **EMOTIVITY** is about whether the voice brings affective life to the text, engaging listeners emotionally and maintaining their interest through expressive variation.

Inclusion criteria

- Expressive vs. flat delivery
- Animated, lively, engaging delivery
- Warm, cheerful, enthusiastic vocal quality
- Lifeless, flat, robotic, mechanical delivery
- Emotional appropriateness to content
- Engaging vs. boring delivery
- Conveying emotion or feeling through voice

Examples

"Another criticism was that the voices were similar to those of a speech synthesis or text-to-speech software. Overall, evaluators who mentioned the voice aspect preferred more interpretive voices." (Luque & Soler, 2023)

"All the participants in this group preferred the mood- congruent clip they had been exposed to in Experiment 2. A large number (71.4 per cent) believed that the voice quality of the AD had enhanced their understanding of the scene's emotional landscape and only 28.6 per cent did not regard it as particularly helpful. The reasons for their preference for the mood- congruent clip varied, but most of them attributed this to a 'more emotionally loaded AD voice' (57.1 per cent) and to 'more detailed and better description in the AD script' (42.8 per cent)." (Iglesias-Fernández et al., 2015)

4. Sound [PARENT]

Definition

The technical audio engineering dimension of AD quality, concerning the recording, processing, and integration of the AD audio track: whether the recording is clean and free from technical defects (**FIDELITY**), and whether the AD track is appropriately **MIXED** with the original soundtrack in terms of absolute loudness (**VOLUME**) and relative balance (**BALANCE**). **SOUND** quality is the responsibility of audio engineers and sound technicians, and it involves all technical processes after vocal performance is complete. **SOUND** failures are due to audio engineering: the recording has noise or distortion, the AD track is too loud or too quiet, or the AD overwhelms (or is overwhelmed by) the original soundtrack.

Scope

SOUND encompasses all technical audio engineering processes that occur after the voice talent completes their performance. It concerns the technical quality of the audio signal and the integration of AD with the original media soundtrack. Items belong in **SOUND** when they concern technical audio processing: recording quality, noise reduction, volume levels, mixing, and audio balance. **SOUND** is distinct from **SERVICE** (institutional provision/user access to AD), **SCRIPT** (what is written before performance) and **VOICE** (how voice talent performs the script). The boundary is clear: if the quality concern is about technical audio engineering after performance, it is **SOUND**; if about what was written, it is **SCRIPT**; if about vocal performance, it is **VOICE**; if about how users access the service or delivery systems, it is **SERVICE**.

Data grounding

The data supports a two-child structure for **SOUND**. (3.5%)

- a. **FIDELITY** (23 items): recording quality and freedom from technical defects (noise, distortion, interference);
- b. **MIXING** (70 items): post-recording integration of AD with original soundtrack (27 **VOLUME** items on loudness levels and 32 **BALANCE** items on relative integration and ducking/dipping).

SOUND cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
FIDELITY	Is the recording clean?	Noise, distortion, & clarity
MIXING	How is AD integrated?	Volume & balance with soundtrack

4.1. Fidelity [CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **SOUND** quality concerned with the technical integrity and clarity of the recorded audio signal, including freedom from noise, distortion, interference, and other technical defects. **FIDELITY** asks: is the recording clean? Is the signal clear? Are there technical problems that degrade the audio quality? **FIDELITY** is the foundation of **SOUND** quality: if the recording itself is compromised by noise or distortion, no amount of skilled **MIXING** can fully compensate.

FIDELITY operates at the recording stage—the quality of the captured audio signal before any **MIXING** or processing. It involves:

- **Noise:** unwanted sounds in the recording (hiss, hum, static, background noise, environmental interference)
- **Distortion:** signal degradation (clipping, compression artifacts, harmonic distortion)
- **Clarity:** clean, crisp audio signal free from muddiness or muffling
- **Interference:** external audio contamination (radio frequency interference, electrical noise, crosstalk)

Poor **FIDELITY** manifests as: hissy recordings, noisy background, muffled sound, distorted audio, interference, or technical artifacts. Good **FIDELITY** means a clean, clear signal that faithfully represents the voice talent's performance without technical degradation.

FIDELITY is distinct from **VOICE** concerns: a voice talent can have poor articulation (**VOICE** → **ARTICULATION**) recorded with perfect fidelity, or excellent articulation recorded with poor fidelity (noisy, distorted). Similarly, audio can have perfect fidelity but be too quiet (**SOUND** → **MIXING** → **VOLUME**) or poorly balanced with the soundtrack (**MIXING** → **BALANCE**).

Inclusion criteria

- Recording quality and technical clarity
- Presence or absence of noise (hiss, hum, static, background noise)
- Distortion or signal degradation
- Muffled or muddy audio quality
- Interference (electrical, radio frequency, environmental)
- Technical defects in the recording
- Audio cleanup and noise reduction processes
- Recording environment quality (soundproofing, acoustic treatment)

Examples

"The next category is the audio quality, where we addressed two issues highlighted by evaluators: the presence of noise and the emphasis on the human quality of the voices. We cleaned the audio tracks as much as we could, but a degree of interference was

unavoidable given that it was a semi-professional project recorded at home." (Luque & Soler, 2023)

"Use high-quality microphones and audio-recording facilities to provide clear description that matches or exceeds the quality of the program audio." (DCMP, n.d.)

4.2. Mixing^[CHILD]

Definition

The dimension of **SOUND** quality concerned with the post-recording integration of the AD track with the original media soundtrack. **MIXING** concerns the absolute loudness of AD track (**VOLUME**) and the relative balance between AD and the original audio elements, including dialogue, music, and sound effects (**BALANCE**). **MIXING** quality asks: Is the AD track at an appropriate loudness? Does it integrate well with the original soundtrack, or does it overwhelm (or get overwhelmed by) other audio elements?

MIXING is where the separately recorded AD track is combined with the original media audio. It involves two related but distinct processes:

- a. **VOLUME**: Setting the absolute loudness level of the AD track—ensuring it's audible but not excessively loud. This is about the AD track's level in isolation: "Is it loud enough to hear?" or "Is it too loud?"
- b. **BALANCE**: Managing the relative levels between AD and the original soundtrack—ensuring AD doesn't drown out important dialogue/music/effects, and that the original doesn't drown out AD. This includes ducking (lowering background audio when AD speaks) and ensuring AD does not compete with important sound elements.

Good **MIXING** creates a cohesive audio experience where AD integrates seamlessly with original media. Poor **MIXING** results in AD that is inaudible (too quiet), aggressive (too loud), competing with dialogue (poor balance), or drowning out important sound effects (poor balance).

4.2.1. Volume^[grandchild]

Definition

The absolute loudness level of the AD track, ensuring it is audible to the target audience without being excessively loud. **VOLUME** quality concerns whether the AD track can be heard clearly (not too quiet) and whether it is comfortable to listen to (not too loud). **VOLUME** is about the AD track's loudness in isolation, independent of how it balances with other audio elements.

VOLUME addresses the fundamental question: "Can the audience hear the AD?" This seems simple, but complicated by several factors:

- User control: Many users want adjustable AD volume separate from program volume
- Passage-specific needs: Different scenes may require different AD volumes
- Target audience variations: User have different hearing sensitivities and preferences
- Playback context: Theater vs. home vs. mobile device may require different volume approaches

VOLUME is distinct from **BALANCE**: an AD track can be at an appropriate volume but still be overwhelmed by loud music (poor **BALANCE**), or it can be mixed perfectly with the soundtrack (good **BALANCE**) but AD can be too quiet overall (poor **VOLUME**).

Inclusion criteria

- Loudness level of AD track
- Whether AD is audible or inaudible
- AD being too loud or too quiet
- Volume level adjustments
- User ability to control AD volume
- Adjusting AD volume for different passages or scenes
- Adequate volume for audience to hear
- Volume matching between AD and program

Examples

"Kernel density estimation showed significantly lower mean loudness in published ADs than in novice ADs. Additionally, a significant negative correlation existed between perceived AD volume quality and mean film loudness during AD presentation across all AD sets." (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2024)

"...issues regarding the sound intensity (volume) of the music soundtrack and the AD track have also been raised as having a bearing on the effect of the AD experience..." (Iglesias-Fernández et al., 2015)

4.2.2. Balance[grandchild]

Definition

The relative integration and level relationship between the AD track and original soundtrack (dialogue, music, sound effects, ambient sound). **BALANCE** quality concerns whether AD integrates harmoniously with the original audio, whether AD can be heard without drowning out important sound elements, and whether important sound elements don't drown out AD. **BALANCE** includes ducking and dipping techniques to temporarily lower background audio when AD speaks.

BALANCE is the most complex aspect of AD **MIXING** because it requires managing multiple competing priorities:

- AD must be clearly audible (should not be drowned out by music or effects)
- Important dialogue must remain clear (AD should not overlap or compete)
- Atmosphere must be preserved (music and ambient sound should not be eliminated)
- Sound effects should be maintained (they convey narrative information)

BALANCE techniques include:

- **Ducking/Dipping:** Automatically lowering background audio (music, ambient sound) when AD speaks, then raising it again when AD finishes
- **Selective mixing:** Lowering some elements (background music) while preserving others (dialogue, important effects)
- **Dynamic adjustment:** Changing the balance throughout the program based on what is happening on screen
- **Spatial separation:** Using stereo or surround sound positioning to separate AD from other elements

Good **BALANCE** creates a seamless audio experience where AD feels integrated rather than imposed. Poor **BALANCE** results in AD competing with dialogue, drowning out important sound effects, or being overwhelmed by music. The goal is clarity for AD without sacrificing the audio atmosphere of the original work.

Inclusion criteria

- Integration of AD with original soundtrack
- Balance between AD and dialogue/music/sound effects
- Ducking or dipping background audio for AD
- AD drowning out important sound elements
- AD being drowned out by music or effects
- Competing audio elements
- Allowing atmosphere and background sound to come through
- Mixing AD with original audio
- Relative levels between AD and program audio
- AD interfering with or being interfered by original audio

Examples

"A majority of participants preferred audio ducking (the practice of lowering background volume when AD is being read), and all did not want AD to interrupt or overlap with dialogue." (Jiang & Zhu, 2021)

"For a 5.1 Printmaster(PM), dip center channel only for descriptive events. For very loud sections or for films with very wide dynamic range, it's acceptable to dip the Left and Right channels of a 5.1 PM as well, generally no more than -6db, and sparingly up to -12db when absolutely necessary. For a 2.0 Printmaster, dip both channels accordingly." (Netflix, 2023)

Methods of AD quality assessment

Definition

The methodological framework describing how AD quality is evaluated in research. This encompasses four fundamental dimensions: **who** evaluates quality (**EVALUATOR**), **which** research paradigm(s) guide the inquiry (**RESEARCH PARADIGM**), **how** data is collected from evaluators (**DATA COLLECTION METHOD**), and **what** instruments are used to measure or assess quality (**MEASUREMENT TOOL**). Together, these four dimensions provide a taxonomy of quality assessment practices in AD research.

This framework was not subject to collaborative coding, as its application involved procedural rather than interpretive decisions. For further details on the methods and related findings, please refer to the case appendices and the relevant sections of the paper.

Challenges and limitations in AD quality

Definition

The various barriers, constraints, and systemic issues that impede the achievement, provision, or assessment of AD quality. This encompasses obstacles at multiple stages of the AD lifecycle, ranging from high-level institutional and economic structures to the practical execution of the craft, the characteristics of the users, and the limitations of research methodologies.

Scope

This framework describes what impedes AD quality, categorizing obstacles across five levels: policy and power structures (**GOVERNANCE**), commercial and operational realities (**MARKET**), creative and cognitive demands (**CRAFT**), audience heterogeneity and psychology (**USER**), and methodological or data gaps (**RESEARCH**). It is categorically distinct from the observable features of AD (**QUALITY DIMENSIONS**) and the procedures used to evaluate them (**METHODS OF QUALITY AD ASSESSMENT**).

CHALLENGES AND LIMITATIONS IN AD QUALITY cheat sheet

Parent	Question	Focus
GOVERNANCE-LEVEL	What systemic barriers limit AD quality?	Policy, standards, power
MARKET-LEVEL	What market/industry barriers limit AD quality?	Cost, scale, labor, distribution
CRAFT-LEVEL	What production/craft barriers limit AD quality?	Source constraints, workload, workflow
USER-LEVEL	What user factors complicate AD quality?	Diversity, preferences, feedback bias
RESEARCH-LEVEL	What research barriers limit AD quality progress?	Evaluation bias, definitional issues, data gaps

1. Governance-level **[PARENT]**

Definition

Systemic barriers arising from policy, regulation, standard-setting, and power structures that govern AD provision. **GOVERNANCE** challenges reflect inadequacies in the institutional frameworks that should ensure quality AD: laws prioritizing quantity over quality, fragmented or contradictory standards offering poor guidance, and exclusion of disabled users from decisions affecting them. These challenges require solutions at the highest organizational levels—legislation, regulation, industry-wide standard-setting, and power redistribution.

Scope

Items belong in **GOVERNANCE** when they describe failures or limitations in policy, regulation, standards, or decision-making power structures. The key distinction: **GOVERNANCE** challenges

require systemic/institutional solutions (new laws, reformed standards, inclusivity), whereas **MARKET** challenges require commercial/operational solutions (funding, training, technology). For example: “lack of budget for AD” is **MARKET**; “lack of legal mandate for AD” is **GOVERNANCE**. “Describers disagree on approach” is **CRAFT**; “standards are contradictory” is **GOVERNANCE**. **GOVERNANCE** challenges reflect structural deficits in institutional frameworks, not operational execution problems.

Data grounding

GOVERNANCE challenges account for 84 coded items (18.7% of 448 total), spanning: **QUANTITY-OVER-QUALITY** (20 items), **FRAGMENTED STANDARDS** (41 items), and **USER MARGINALIZATION** (22 items).

GOVERNANCE – LEVEL cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
QUANTITY-OVER-QUALITY	Do rules prioritize volume over quality?	Quotas without quality enforcement
FRAGMENTED STANDARDS AND GUIDELINES	Are standards inconsistent?	Contradictory, vague, & incomplete guidance
USER MARGINALIZATION IN DECISION-MAKING	Are users excluded from governance?	“Nothing about us without us” gaps

1.1. Quantity-over-quality [CHILD]

Definition

Regulatory frameworks that mandate minimum quantities of audio-described content (quota requirements) without corresponding quality standards, enforcement mechanisms, or penalties for poor quality. This policy design flaw creates perverse incentives: providers focus on meeting numerical targets (percentage of programming hours) rather than ensuring quality, leading to compliant-but-inadequate AD that technically satisfies legal obligations while failing user needs.

Inclusion criteria

- Laws/regulations mandating AD quantity (hours, percentages) without quality standards
- Minimum quota systems without enforcement mechanisms
- Compliance-driven AD provision focused on meeting numerical targets
- Regulatory gaps: quantity mandates exist but quality requirements absent
- Systems where providers meet quotas but users report poor quality
- “Checking boxes” mentality: legal **COMPLIANCE** without substantive accessibility

Examples

"British audiovisual regulations impose minimum quotas for subtitling, audio description, and sign language to make content more accessible to people with visual or hearing impairment. However, these minimum requirements do not ensure full user satisfaction." (García-Prieto & Aguaded, 2021)

"Circling back from professionals to end-users, BI4 highlighted the irony where automation theoretically offering more options was instead experienced as foreclosing quality and opportunity." (Bennett et al., 2025)

1. 2. Fragmented standards and guidelines^[CHILD]

Definition

The proliferation of contradictory, vague, incomplete, and intuition-based AD standards and guidelines across countries, organizations, and contexts, creating confusion, inconsistency, and lack of authoritative quality benchmarks. **FRAGMENTATION** manifests as: different countries mandating incompatible approaches, standards omitting key quality aspects (e.g., service, vocal delivery, audio production), vague specifications unoperationalizable in practice, and guidelines based on professional intuition rather than evidence or user research.

Inclusion criteria

- Contradictory standards across jurisdictions/organizations
- Vague, unoperationalizable guidelines ("vivid," "appropriate")
- Standards omitting key quality dimensions (service, delivery, production)
- Guidelines based on intuition/tradition rather than evidence
- Lack of international harmonization
- Absence of authoritative quality benchmarks
- Conflicting advice on fundamental issues (objectivity, person, timing)

Examples

"AD guidelines developed in Poland and abroad offer conflicting formatting recommendations." (Kajzer-Wietrzny & Tymczyńska, 2015)

"Audio description (AD) has been developing very unevenly across Europe. In some countries (such as the UK) AD has already come of age, whereas in others (such as Greece) it is still at the crawling stage. As a result, countries belonging to the former category have worked out national AD standards and practices (which, however, differ from country to country, as does the quality of ADs), whereas those in the latter group are lagging far behind with no formal principles in place to guide audio describers in their work." (Mazur & Chmiel, 2012)

1.3. User marginalization in decision-making [CHILD]

Definition

The systemic exclusion of blind and partially sighted users from policymaking, standard-setting, and quality-defining processes that affect AD provision. This governance failure violates the disability rights principle **“nothing about us without us,”** resulting in decisions largely made by sighted stakeholders (regulators, producers, researchers) without meaningful consultation with or representation of the disabled users whose access needs are at stake. Manifestations include: policies designed without user input, standards based on expert opinion not user research, program selection without AD user consultation, and power dynamics privileging sighted “expertise” over lived disability experience.

Inclusion criteria

- Policies/standards developed without user consultation
- Decision-making power held exclusively by sighted stakeholders
- “Nothing about us without us” violations
- Ableism/capacitism in institutional structures
- Program selection, commissioning decisions excluding AD users
- Expertise hierarchies privileging sighted professionals over user experience
- Lack of disabled representation in governing bodies

Examples

“...approaches enshrined by the guidelines are not always those favoured by AD users...” (Fryer, 2019)

There is still a clear gap between the legislations designed to improve digital accessibility and their practical implementation due to the high degree of technical skills required to conformance test accessibility, the costs involved in such a process, effective resourcing to address this issue, and a lack of awareness as to how people with disabilities are likely to engage with such content. (Oncins & Orero, 2021)

2. Market-level [PARENT]

Definition

Barriers arising from the economic, commercial, and operational realities of AD production and distribution within media industries. **MARKET** challenges reflect the business context of AD: high costs and low profitability making AD economically unsustainable; insufficient provision relative to the sheer volume of content; labor shortages and reliance on inadequately trained describers; access barriers beyond AD itself (venues, devices, interfaces); inability to

customize AD for the diverse user base within commercial constraints; and licensing/distribution systems that ignore or impede accessibility.

Scope

Items belong in **MARKET** when they describe economic, commercial, operational, or industry-structural barriers to quality AD. The key distinction: **MARKET** challenges stem from how AD is produced, funded, distributed, and consumed as a commercial service, whereas **GOVERNANCE** challenges stem from policy/regulation, **CRAFT** challenges from creative/technical execution, **USER** challenges from audience characteristics, and **RESEARCH** challenges from knowledge/methodology gaps. **MARKET** challenges require business solutions (funding, efficiency, training, infrastructure), not policy reform (**GOVERNANCE**), artistic improvement (**CRAFT**), accommodation of diversity (**USER**), or methodological advancement (**RESEARCH**). For example: “AD is expensive” is **MARKET**; “no laws mandate AD funding” is **GOVERNANCE**. “Describers lack training” is **MARKET**; “describers disagree on approach” may be **CRAFT** or **GOVERNANCE** (fragmented standards).

Data grounding

MARKET challenges account for 162 items (36.1%), the largest category being: **SCALABILITY CONSTRAINTS** (51 items), **LACK OF PROVISION** (56 items), **LABOR SHORTAGES AND DEPROFESSIONALIZATION** (12 items), **ACCESS-TO-ACCESS BARRIERS** (14 items), **ONE-SIZE-FITS-ALL** (9 items), **LICENSING** (7 items). The high total reflects AD’s commercial reality: it is an expensive, specialized service in a cost-conscious industry, creating pervasive economic barriers.

MARKET-LEVEL cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
SCALABILITY CONSTRAINTS	Can AD scale to content volume?	Cost, time, capacity
LACK OF PROVISION	Is there enough AD available?	Coverage & variety gaps
LABOR SHORTAGES AND DEPROFESSIONALIZATION	Are there enough trained professionals?	Training, shortages, deskilling
ACCESS-TO-ACCESS BARRIERS	Can users access AD in practice?	Devices, venues, interfaces
ONE-SIZE-FITS-ALL LIMITATIONS	Can AD be customized to users?	No variants or personalization
ACCESS-INDIFFERENT LICENSING AND DISTRIBUTION	Do rights/distribution block AD?	Licensing, pass-through, files

2.1. Scalability constraints_[CHILD]

Definition

The economic and temporal barriers that make AD production costly, slow, and difficult to **SCALE** to meet the volume of content requiring description. **SCALABILITY CONSTRAINTS** manifest as:

high production costs (\$1,500–\$4,000 per hour of content), slow turnaround time (one describer-week per two hours of content), labor-intensive processes requiring skilled humans, and resulting inability to scale AD provision for vast content libraries (streaming platforms, social media, legacy archives). These constraints create a fundamental tension: AD demand grows exponentially (more platforms, more content), but AD supply scales linearly at best (requires human labor), making accessibility economically unviable under current production models.

Inclusion criteria

- Production cost barriers (high per-hour cost)
- Time/turnaround barriers (slow, labor-intensive)
- Economic unsustainability at scale
- Tension between content volume and production capacity
- Funding insufficiency (can't afford comprehensive AD)
- Cost-driven quality compromises (rushing to reduce cost)
- Business model problems (AD doesn't generate revenue, only costs)
- Platform-specific scalability (VoD, social media, archives)

Examples

"Relying heavily on human resource, AD is currently an expensive part of the post-production process for traditional media companies, making it challenging to provide comprehensive media access." (Braun & Starr, 2019)

"A spelling mistake may lead to a stumble or hesitation, necessitating a re-record. This is expensive in terms of time and studio costs..." (Fryer, 2019)

"...many videos lack AD and remain inaccessible as traditional approaches involve expensive professional production..." (Natalie et al., 2023)

2. 2. Lack of provision^[CHILD]

Definition

The insufficient availability of audio-described content relative to the total volume of media requiring description, resulting in limited user choice and inadequate access to cultural, educational, and entertainment content. Lack of provision manifests as: most content lacking AD (even when legally mandated minimums are met), emerging platforms (social media, VoD) with minimal coverage, and users unable to access desired content because AD does not exist. This is an outcome of scalability constraints, policy failures, and low commercial prioritization, reflecting the gap between what should be accessible and what actually is.

Inclusion criteria

- Insufficient AD relative to content volume

- Limited coverage despite legal mandates
- Most content lacking AD (< 10-20% typical)
- Museums/institutions with partial AD (only highlights)
- User inability to access desired content
- Platform-specific gaps (VoD, social media, archives)
- Content selection problems (wrong titles described)

Examples

"...audio described works constitute only a small percentage of their collection, usually the museum's highlights." (Luque & Soler, 2023)

"Our findings show that the most prominent challenge is the lack of available AD." (Jiang & Zhu, 2021)

2. 3. Labor shortages and deprofessionalization ^[CHILD]

Definition

The insufficient supply of trained, professional audio describers relative to demand, combined with industry trends toward **DEPROFESSIONALIZATION**: reliance on amateurs, volunteers, or professionals from adjacent fields (translation, subtitling) without specialized AD training. **LABOR CHALLENGES** manifest as: too few describers for workload, training bottlenecks (limited programs, expensive certification), long entry pathways, and quality degradation as untrained practitioners produce AD without requisite skills. This reflects a nascent profession struggling to professionalize amid low compensation, high skill requirements, and insufficient training infrastructure.

Inclusion criteria

- Insufficient trained describers relative to demand
- Reliance on untrained amateurs/volunteers
- Adjacent professionals (translators) without AD training
- Training bottlenecks (few programs, expensive, long pathways)
- Lack of professional recognition/status
- Low compensation driving low supply
- Quality degradation from untrained practitioners

Examples

"Broadcasters are processing ever greater volumes of audio described content but without the time or personnel to maintain the desired quality of AD. They are unable to provide adequate training, in part because there is very little quality AD training available. " (Hyks & Blokland, 2023)

"In the Chinese mainland, although some professionals participated, most of the people engaged in AD services are part-time, amateur volunteers." (Yang et al., 2023)

2. 4. Access-to-access barriers^[CHILD]

Definition

Obstacles that prevent **BLIND AND PARTIALLY SIGHTED** users from accessing AD even when AD exists, including: inaccessible venue infrastructure (wayfinding, seating, transportation), inaccessible technology interfaces (streaming platforms, apps, devices difficult to navigate), device-related isolation (headsets in cinemas limit social experience, device unavailability), information barriers (inability to find AD-equipped content, unreliable pre-visit information, lack of clear signage/guidance). These are "second-order" barriers: AD is provided (**first-order access**) but users cannot reach it (**second-order failure**). **ACCESS-TO-ACCESS CHALLENGES** reflect that AD is necessary but insufficient for accessibility: users must navigate physical spaces, digital interfaces, and information systems designed for sighted users.

Inclusion criteria

- Venue/architectural barriers (wayfinding, seating, facilities)
- Device/technology barriers (headsets, inaccessible interfaces)
- Digital platform navigation difficulties
- Information barriers (finding AD content, pre-visit info)
- Transportation challenges to venues
- Social isolation (headsets prevent shared experience)
- Physical accessibility gaps beyond AD itself

Examples

"Another factor that influences whether to go to a play is the level of accessibility of the hall and the specific seating I get. I use a guide dog and if there isn't enough space between the rows, so the dog can lie down comfortably, I cannot attend. Also, sometimes these seats increase the cost of the ticket – so again, I cannot attend." (Ferziger et al., 2020)

"...simply providing x is not sufficient if the means to access it is not also provided..." (Fryer, 2021)

"Participants recognised that there were a number of barriers to accessing AD." (Peaty et al., 2023)

2. 5. One-size-fits-all limitations [CHILD]

Definition

The commercial and technical inability to provide customizable, differentiated, or personalized audio description that accommodates diverse user needs, preferences, and contexts. **ONE-SIZE-FITS-ALL** manifests as: single AD version per content (no detail levels, style variants, or personalization options), assumption of homogeneous audience (standardized approach ignoring user diversity), lack of customization features (speed control, detail selection, multiple tracks), and economic/technical barriers to producing multiple versions. This reflects **MARKET** constraint: customization warrants additional **production** cost and infrastructure, economically prohibitive at scale.

Inclusion criteria

- Single AD version per content (no customization)
- Assumption of homogeneous audience
- Inability to provide detail level options
- No personalization features (speed, style, density)
- Economic barriers to multiple versions
- Technical limitations preventing customization
- Standardized approach ignoring user diversity

Examples

"Although the AD user might seem to be the customer, at no stage does an AD user attending a live performance have choice over which AD provider to use. That is a decision already made by the venue, the producer or the company, whichever has taken responsibility for making the performance accessible." (Fryer, 2019)

Another limitation of VideoA1ly is the lack of customization options tailored to the specific preferences and needs of BLV individuals. While our approach relies on general AD guidelines, it does not currently support personalized adjustments based on individual user preferences [25, 32, 56], such as preferred levels of detail or focus on specific types of content (e.g., action vs. emotional tone). (Li et al., 2025)

2. 6. Access-indifferent licensing and distribution [CHILD]

Definition

Commercial **LICENSING**, **DISTRIBUTION**, and rights management practices that ignore, prevent, or complicate AD provision by treating accessibility as afterthought or externality rather than core product feature. Manifestations include: copyright restrictions preventing AD creation/sharing, content acquisition deals excluding or not specifying AD files,

incompatible file formats in **DISTRIBUTION** chains, **LICENSING** agreements silent on accessibility obligations, and lack of AD "pass-through" in international content sales. This reflects market structures designed without accessibility in mind, creating systemic barriers to AD availability and quality.

Inclusion criteria

- Copyright/ **LICENSING** barriers to AD creation
- Content deals excluding AD files
- File format incompatibility issues
- **DISTRIBUTION** chains breaking accessibility
- International content losing AD in transit
- Lack of contractual AD requirements
- AD as afterthought in commercial planning

Examples

"AD often lacks permanence. It may disappear or be altered—sometimes detrimentally—when media transfers platforms [13], as B5 witnessed his carefully crafted AD script and human narration replaced with lower-quality TTS when the film transferred to a new streaming platform." (Bennett et al., 2025)

"...several respondents highlighted the challenges of including access service files in content acquisition deals given that these files are often not usable by the acquiring provider in their existing form. Channel 4 said that the reworking needed to such files can approach the work to create access service files from scratch. Both the BBC and BT said that technical formats used for access service files should be agreed at an industry level, with BT stating that our Guidelines should include a recommendation for industry collaboration on standardisation." (Ofcom, 2024b)

3. Craft-level **[PARENT]**

Definition

Barriers arising from the creative, technical, and cognitive demands of AD production itself—the inherent difficulties of the AD craft. **CRAFT** challenges include: external constraints imposed by source materials (fast editing, dialogue density, limited audio space); describers' struggles with information density (users wanting more detail than time permits); high cognitive workload of multimodal integration under time pressure; and workflow complications from templates, translation chains, and technical systems. These challenges reflect that AD is fundamentally difficult skilled work: describers must watch, comprehend, select, compose, time, and produce descriptions while juggling multiple constraints—a demanding cognitive and creative task.

Scope

Items belong in **CRAFT** when they describe creative, technical, or cognitive challenges inherent to AD production work, distinct from: **GOVERNANCE** (policy/standards), **MARKET** (commercial structures), **USER** (audience characteristics), or **RESEARCH** (evaluation/methodology). **CRAFT** challenges are what describers face in doing their work: making editorial decisions under constraints, writing effectively, integrating multimodal information, timing precisely, working within technical systems. For example: “fast editing leaves no audio gaps” is **CRAFT** (source constraint); “users disagree on what to describe” may be User. **CRAFT** is about the work itself—the doing of AD—not the context (**MARKET** / **GOVERNANCE**) or reception (**USER** / **RESEARCH**).

Data grounding

CRAFT challenges account for 66 items (14.7%), distributed: **SOURCE CONSTRAINTS** (29 items), **INADEQUATE DENSITY** in descriptions (9 items), **COGNITIVE WORKLOAD** (21 items), **WORKFLOW CONSTRAINTS** (7 items). High **COGNITIVE WORKLOAD** emphasis reflects recognition that AD is demanding mental work.

CRAFT-LEVEL cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
SOURCE-MATERIAL CONSTRAINTS	Does the source leave room for AD?	No gaps, fast pace, dense audio
INADEQUACY OF DESCRIPTIONS	Is AD “not enough”?	Missing detail, low density
HIGH COGNITIVE WORKLOAD	Is the task cognitively demanding?	Multitasking under time pressure
WORKFLOW CONSTRAINTS	Do workflows hinder quality?	Templates, pivot chains, rigid systems

3.1. Source-material constraints^[CHILD]

Definition

Limitations imposed by the audiovisual source material’s characteristics that make AD difficult, impossible, or incomplete: fast-paced editing with rapid shot changes, dialogue-dense scenes without audio gaps, soundtrack features (music, sound effects) occupying audio space, narrative structures requiring continuous description, and visual complexity exceeding available description time. These constraints are external to describer skill or **MARKET** resources—they reflect that some content is inherently difficult to describe within AD’s operational parameters (which is to avoid overlap dialogue, fit in gaps, maintain narrative flow).

Inclusion criteria

- Fast-paced editing/shot changes
- Dialogue-dense scenes (no audio gaps)
- Soundtrack occupying audio space (music, effects)

- Visual complexity exceeding available description time
- Narrative structures requiring continuous description
- Genre-specific description difficulties
- Inherent “undescribability” of certain content

Examples

“Another challenging feature involved in audio description is the scarcity of intervals into which audio describers struggle to fit the descriptions. Audio description is a constrained type of translation in that it must be designed within the limitations of the silent slots, the importance of what needs to be relayed and also the reception abilities of the receivers; the text needs to be clear and concise.” (Erkazancı-Durmuş & Okyayuz, 2023)

“Because people creating a movie trailer try to cram a lot of information in a particularly short period of time, there is not much room to insert audio descriptions.” (Nakajima & Mitobe, 2022)

3. 2. Inadequacy of descriptions [CHILD]

Definition

User-reported insufficiency of information, detail, or depth in ADs: descriptions lack necessary visual details, omit elements users want/need to know, provide surface-level coverage without meaningful depth, or feel sparse relative to visual richness. Inadequacy reflects tension between what users want (comprehensive visual access) and what AD provides (selective, constrained description), manifesting as complaints about low information density, missing details, inadequate elaboration, or inability to form mental images from provided description.

Inclusion criteria

- User complaints about insufficient detail/information
- Sparse descriptions (low information density)
- Missing visual elements users need
- Surface-level coverage without depth
- Inability to form adequate mental images
- Inadequate elaboration/explanation
- Omission of important details

Examples

“The audio describers in the focus-group study further state that in the Turkish case the frequency and the density of AD can sometimes be a slippery slope. In some cases, in the Turkish tradition, the end users will report that they had the feeling that something was not being relayed if the silent interval is long (even a few seconds); thus, Turkish audio describers tend to refrain from leaving too many silent intervals without AD. But on the other hand, they

must balance this with making sure that they are not producing verbal garbage that does not facilitate access or repetition of the information that is already provided by the audial track (e.g. the sounds of a storm) or repeating themselves. In such cases, the end users also comment on this extensive AD as a negative feature." (Erkazancı-Durmuş & Okyayuz, 2023)

3. 3. High cognitive workload^[CHILD]

Definition

The demanding cognitive and perceptual labor required to create ADs: describers must simultaneously watch/comprehend visual content, listen to/process audio track, identify narratively critical visual elements, make rapid editorial decisions about what/how to describe, compose concise/vivid language, time descriptions precisely to fit available gaps, monitor overall narrative flow, and maintain consistency—all under time pressure and within strict constraints. This mental multitasking is cognitively exhausting and error-prone, contributing to quality variability and limiting production speed.

Inclusion criteria

- Cognitive demands of multimodal information processing
- Mental workload of simultaneous tasks
- Decision-making complexity/cognitive load
- Time pressure increasing cognitive stress
- Mental fatigue from AD production
- Error-proneness from cognitive overload
- Difficulty/complexity of AD as skilled work

Examples

"...this process is challenging. It requires attending to content provided by different sources, ongoing integration of the auditory input, and incorporation of the information with previous knowledge, experience, and expectations of the participant..." (Ferziger et al., 2020)

"The complex intersemiotic nature of AD makes it a very challenging form of audiovisual translation as it requires mastering the art of attentive observation and careful selection and apt transfer of intersemiotic content into verbal signs, coupled with good synchronisation skills." (Kajzer-Wietrzny & Tymczyńska, 2015)

3. 4. Workflow constraints^[CHILD]

Definition

Technical, procedural, and organizational barriers in AD production workflows that impede quality or efficiency: locked timecodes in templates restricting describer flexibility, translation chains introducing “telephone game” errors (source → pivot language → target language), loss of local cultural specificity in global distribution, managing multiple language/dialect versions, template-based production sacrificing nuance for consistency, and technical systems imposing rigid structures. These constraints reflect that AD production occurs within complex technical and organizational systems that can hinder rather than help quality.

Inclusion criteria

- Template/timecode rigidity
- Translation chain errors (pivot languages)
- Loss of local/cultural specificity in global distribution
- Multilingual/multidialectal management complexity
- Technical system constraints on describer flexibility
- Workflow inefficiencies creating quality problems
- Procedural/organizational barriers to optimal AD

Examples

"Another potential challenge, according to the participants, is the quality of the templates – as one participant noted, the introduction of a template workflow will be effective only if the resulting audio description is, at a minimum, comparable in quality to the audio description created entirely from scratch. We assume that someone who created this English template or translated it into English did it so well that we won't do it better. But in subtitling, template quality is often an issue. And it's bound to happen in audio description, too." (Jankowska, 2024)

"The locking of templates was the issue that was brought up most frequently. All participants who discussed potential obstacles expressed their disapproval of the impossibility of editing both cueing and content, citing negative effects on the product's quality and the translators' working conditions." (Jankowska, 2024)

4. User-level^[PARENT]

Definition

Barriers arising from characteristics, circumstances, and psychology of blind and partially sighted AD **USERS** themselves: the heterogeneity of **USER** population (diverse needs, abilities, preferences), conflicting preferences among **USERS** (incompatible desires preventing universal satisfaction), and gratitude bias (reluctance to criticize due to low expectations or

fear of losing service). **USER** challenges reflect that the audience for AD is not monolithic—**USERS** differ in vision status, experience, knowledge, preferences, and power—creating difficulties for universal quality standards and complicating quality assessment.

Scope

Items belong in **USER** when they describe characteristics of AD **USERS** or their relationships to AD provision that create challenges for quality achievement or assessment. This is distinct from: **MARKET** (commercial), **GOVERNANCE** (policy), **CRAFT** (production), or **RESEARCH** (evaluation methods). **USER** challenges are about who **USERS** are (diverse), what they want (conflicting), and how they respond (gratitude bias), not about service structures (**MARKET**), professional practices (**CRAFT**), or institutional frameworks (**GOVERNANCE**).

Data grounding

USER challenges account for 61 items (13.6%), **AUDIENCE VARIABILITY** (22 items), **CONFLICTING PREFERENCES** (28 items), **GRATITUDE BIAS** (11 items).

USER-LEVEL cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
AUDIENCE VARIABILITY	How diverse are users' needs?	Heterogeneous profiles
CONFLICTING PREFERENCES	Do users want different things?	Trade-offs across users
GRATITUDE BIAS	Do users under-criticize quality?	Reluctance to complain

4.1. Audience variability_[CHILD]

Definition

The heterogeneity of blind and partially sighted AD users across multiple dimensions: **vision status** (congenitally blind, acquired sight loss, total blindness, low vision), **cognitive and perceptual abilities**, educational **background and knowledge** (art literacy, general knowledge), **age**, experience with AD, cultural context, and **individual differences in processing/preference**. This variability means users have genuinely different access needs, comprehension abilities, and quality priorities, complicating universal AD approaches and quality standards.

Inclusion criteria

- Vision status diversity (congenital/acquired, total/low-vision)
- Cognitive ability variations
- Knowledge/expertise differences (art literacy, general knowledge)
- Age-related processing differences
- Experience with AD (novice vs. experienced users)

- Cultural/linguistic diversity
- Individual processing/preference differences

Examples

"The individual differences in terms of sensory or cognitive access to information will always pose a great challenge for perception and reception." (Chica-Núñez & Jiménez-Hurtado, 2020)

"...we noted that the level of vision the participants have influences the amount of content they want." (Wang et al., 2021)

4. 2. Conflicting preferences^[CHILD]

Definition

Incompatible or contradictory user desires regarding AD characteristics that cannot be simultaneously satisfied: some users preferring fast-paced dense description vs. others wanting slow sparse description; objective factual style vs. subjective interpretive style; human narration vs. synthetic speech; minimal AD (only essentials) vs. elaborate AD (rich detail); repetition vs. conciseness. These **CONFLICTS** mean improving AD for some users inherently worsens it for others, complicating universal quality standards and guideline development.

Inclusion criteria

- Incompatible user preferences
- Trade-offs between user desires (helping one group hurts another)
- Subjective quality judgments (disagreement on what's "good")
- Style/approach preferences (objective vs. subjective, etc.)
- Pace/density preferences (fast vs. slow, dense vs. sparse)
- Voice preferences (human vs. TTS)
- Detail preferences (minimal vs. elaborate)

Examples

"...we found that users have drastically different preferences on the level of detail of AD." (Jiang & Zhu, 2021)

"There was a division in preference for pace of description, where some participants preferred the faster theatrical style of LC, while others preferred the slower relaxed style of SC." (Naraine et al., 2018)

4. 3. Gratitude bias^[CHILD]

Definition

The tendency of blind and partially sighted AD users to refrain from criticizing poor-quality AD or providing negative feedback, stemming from: low expectations (“any AD is better than no AD”), fear of losing access (criticism might cause service withdrawal), [GRATITUDE](#) for service provision (feeling thankful limits critique), limited exposure to AD (lack of comparison basis), and power imbalance (users do not feel entitled to demand quality). This bias undermines quality feedback loops, preventing user input from driving improvement and masking quality problems.

Inclusion criteria

- Reluctance to criticize AD
- “Any AD is better than no AD” sentiment
- Fear of service withdrawal if critique
- Low expectations preventing critique
- Limited AD exposure (no comparison)
- Gratitude limiting negative feedback
- Power imbalance (users feel subordinate)

Examples

“For a blind and low vision audience who depend on AD to consume visual media, no AD is the worstcase scenario rather than low-quality AD. As a result, this audience hesitates to wholly reject any alternative, no manner how limited.” (Peaty et al., 2023)

“Although we observed that the final AD output usually contains some missing events, blind users still prefer some descriptions to no information at all.” (Wang et al., 2021)

5. Research-level^[PARENT]

Definition

Barriers arising from knowledge gaps, methodological difficulties, and data limitations in AD quality [RESEARCH](#): [ALGORITHMIC BIAS](#) in automatic evaluation metrics that favor sighted norms, [SUBJECTIVITY OF QUALITY](#) making definition/operationalization elusive, and [DATA SCARCITY](#) limiting [RESEARCH](#) and AI development. [RESEARCH](#) challenges reflect that understanding, measuring, and advancing AD quality is itself difficult—we lack clear quality definitions, reliable measurement tools, and sufficient data to conduct rigorous [RESEARCH](#) or train AI systems.

Scope

Items belong in **RESEARCH** when they describe knowledge, methodology, or data barriers to studying, evaluating, or advancing AD quality. This is distinct from: **GOVERNANCE** (policy/standards), **MARKET** (commercial structures), **CRAFT** (production), or **USER** (audience). **RESEARCH** challenges are epistemological (“what is quality?”), methodological (“how do we measure it?”), and empirical (“what data do we have?”).

Data grounding

RESEARCH challenges account for 75 items (16.7%): **ALGORITHMIC BIAS** (34 items), **SUBJECTIVITY OF QUALITY** (36 items), **DATA SCARCITY** (5 items).

Note on the article’s three limits

The article gathers the research-level constraint into three structural limits: the subjectivity of quality, algorithmic bias, and methodological heterogeneity. The first two correspond directly to the children below. The third—methodological heterogeneity, which hinders comparability and prevents future reviews from synthesizing effects—is not a separately coded node here. It is the cross-study consequence of the incommensurable instruments catalogued under **MEASUREMENT TOOL**, where the same label may carry different evaluative assumptions in different rubrics and so create an appearance of comparability while concealing incommensurability. **DATA SCARCITY** remains a coded node in its own right and covers the availability of corpora rather than the comparability of methods. Code an item about incomparable measures across studies to **SUBJECTIVITY OF QUALITY** where the difficulty is conceptual, and record the instrument under **MEASUREMENT TOOL** where it is operational.

RESEARCH-LEVEL cheat sheet

Child	Question	Focus
ALGORITHMIC BIAS	Are metrics/systems biased?	Sighted-norm bias
SUBJECTIVITY OF QUALITY	Is “quality” hard to pin down?	Elusive/contested concept
DATA SCARCITY	Is there enough data to study/train models?	Limited AD corpora

5.1. Algorithmic bias_[CHILD]

Definition

The systematic tendency of automatic evaluation metrics and AI systems to favor sighted language patterns, sighted-written descriptions, and sighted norms over blind and visually impaired users' preferences, needs, and language patterns. **ALGORITHMIC BIAS** manifests as: **REFERENCE-BASED METRICS** (BLEU, METEOR, ROUGE, CIDEr) assigning higher scores to descriptions resembling sighted references even when blind and partially sighted users prefer

alternatives; penalties for longer descriptions (which BVI users may need); preference for concise phrasing over elaboration; and optimization systems trained on biased metrics producing user-unfriendly AD.

Inclusion criteria

- Automatic metric bias toward sighted norms
- **REFERENCE-BASED METRICS** favoring sighted language
- Penalties for blind and partially sighted users' preferred description styles
- AI optimization producing BVI-unfriendly outputs
- Metrics not correlating with BVI user satisfaction
- Systemic bias in evaluation frameworks
- Metrics "stifling useful model development"

Examples

"...participants identified a fundamental conflict between the drive for culturally competent, blind-centered AD—which values positionality, specificity, and locality—and the current state of gen AI. They noted documented biases regarding representation [63, 66, 68, 106, 112, 118, 119]—a key component of cultural competence. Researchers have surfaced AI's failure to identify non-Western contexts [29, 70, 87] and tendency toward generality that can dilute culturally specific descriptions or artistic intent [43], forewarning it might not produce adequate descriptions of accessories, objects, and environments with the vocabulary or nuance target audiences expect." (Bennett et al., 2025)

"In this work, we show that the most popular evaluation metrics (reference-based metrics) are biased against BLV users and therefore potentially stifle useful model development. Reference-based metrics assign quality scores based on the similarity to humangenerated ground-truth descriptions and are widely accepted as neutrally representing the needs of all users. However, we find that these metrics are more strongly correlated with sighted participant ratings than BLV ratings, and these systems often do not directly address the needs of BLV users..." (Kapur & Kreiss, 2024)

5. 2. Subjectivity of quality^[CHILD]

Definition

The inherently elusive, context-dependent, and perspectival nature of "quality" in AD: quality is **SUBJECTIVE** (varies by evaluator), relative (depends on purpose, genre, user), multidimensional (no single definition), and contested (stakeholders disagree). This creates fundamental challenges for: defining quality operationally, establishing universal standards, measuring quality objectively, comparing quality across contexts, and adjudicating between competing quality claims. Quality is not an objective property to be discovered but a constructed, negotiated, situated concept.

Inclusion criteria

- Quality as **SUBJECTIVE**/elusive concept
- Difficulty defining quality operationally
- Context-dependence of quality
- Stakeholder disagreements on quality meaning
- Vague quality criteria hard to measure
- "Quality according to what criteria?" questions
- No objective quality standard exists
- Quality as negotiated/constructed concept

Examples

"An evaluation on the quality of audio description can at times be subjective. A product deemed to be of quality for some may not be considered so by others. Also, ages, experience with products with audio description and their habits will also be extremely relevant to their judgement of a products' quality..." (Erkazancı-Durmuş & Okyayuz, 2023)

"...there is no single view of what constitutes quality nor what it takes to produce a quality product." (Fryer, 2019)

5. 3. Data scarcity **[CHILD]**

Definition

The insufficient availability of large-scale, high-quality, well-documented, time-synchronized audio description corpora required for: conducting empirical AD research, analyzing patterns in professional practice, training AI systems to generate or evaluate AD, and developing evidence-based guidelines. **DATA SCARCITY** manifests as: few publicly available AD corpora, limited corpus sizes (hundreds of hours vs. millions needed for AI), lack of metadata (quality annotations, user ratings, context info), absence of multilingual corpora, and proprietary data inaccessible to researchers.

Inclusion criteria

- Insufficient AD corpora for research
- Limited corpus sizes for AI training
- Lack of publicly available AD datasets
- Proprietary/inaccessible AD data
- Absence of quality-annotated corpora
- Missing metadata (user ratings, context)
- Multilingual data gaps
- Technical barriers to corpus compilation

Examples

"Despite recent advancements in multilingual machine translation research, the lack of wellcrafted and time-synchronized AD data impedes the development of audio description translation (ADT) systems that address the needs of multilingual countries such as Switzerland." (Fischer et al., 2024)

"...visual language models for AD generation are limited by a lack of suitable training data..." (Han et al., 2024)